EMV
EMERGENCY
MANAGEMENT
VICTORIA

Victorian Emergency Operations Handbook

Edition 3 – December 2020



Working in conjunction with Communities, Government, Agencies and Business

Authorised and published by Emergency Management Victoria,

121 Exhibition Street, Melbourne, 3000

© State of Victoria 2020

You are free to re-use this work under a Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 licence, provided you credit the State of Victoria (Emergency Management Victoria) as author, indicate if changes were made and comply with the other licence terms. The licence does not apply to any images, photographs or branding, including Government logos.

ISBN 978-0-9944236-0-3 (Print)
ISBN 978-0-9944236-1-0 (pdf)

Published December 2020

If you would like to receive this publication in an accessible format, please email media@emv.vic.gov.au

This document is also available in Word/PDF format at www.emv.vic.gov.au

CONTENTS

FOREWORD **6**

PURPOSE **7**

PART 1 – EMERGENCY RESPONSE ARRANGEMENTS **9**

EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT ARRANGEMENTS **11**

Principles of emergency management 11

Victorian emergency management arrangements 12

Incident tier 22

Regional tier 25

State tier 27

Area of Operation tier 28

Transfer of control 29

Class 3 emergencies 31

SAFETY **36**

Safety first approach 37

Safety considerations 41

Health monitoring 42

Communication of safety information 42

OHS incident reporting 46

INCIDENT MANAGEMENT **47**

Incident Management Systems 47

Incident Controller 52

Deputy Incident Controller 53

Operations Officer 53

Division Commanders 54

Sector Commanders 55

Incident objective 55

Incident action planning 56

Incident communications planning 57

Communicating incident information 59

Emergency management locations 62

Local knowledge 64

Aircraft and aviation 66

PUBLIC INFORMATION **67**
Provision of warnings to the community 67
Warning levels and templates 67
Community meetings 69
Warning channels 70
Community sirens 70
TRAFFIC MANAGEMENT POINTS **71**
Public TMP access 71
EVACUATION **73**
Definition of evacuation 73
The evacuation process 73
Recommendation to evacuate 73
Roles and responsibilities 74
Vulnerable people 78
INITIAL IMPACT ASSESSMENT **79**
Initial Impact Assessment 79
Secondary Impact Assessment 80
RELIEF AND RECOVERY **81**
Transition from response to recovery 81
Relief and recovery coordination 82
Emergency relief and recovery public information sources 83
INFORMATION SYSTEMS **84**
Emergency Management – Common Operating Picture 84
Emergency Management Drive 84
Emergency management webmail 85
Resource requesting 85
LESSONS MANAGEMENT **86**
EM-Share 89
Monitoring 90
Debriefing 90
Reviews 92
Assurance and Learning Unit 92

PART 2 – BUSHFIRE READINESS AND RESPONSE **93**
READINESS AND RESPONSE TO BUSHFIRE **91**
Preparedness arrangements 91
Readiness arrangements 91
Response arrangements 97
Functional areas 99
Post incident 124

PART 3 – FLOOD AND STORM **125**
Flood and storm **127**
Authorising environment 127
Emergency risk management 127
Extreme weather climatology 128
River systems 129
Floodplain management 130
Flood emergency management 130
Total Flood Warning System (TFWS) 131
Levee management 131
Dam management 132
Community resilience 132
Readiness and response 133
Managing the incident response 136
Triage 139
Public information 141
Community safety options 144
Consequence management 145
Relief and recovery 146
After an emergency 146

PART 4 – REFERENCES AND APPENDICES **147**
Further information **149**
Doctrine 150
SCC/RCC/ICC contact list 152

FOREWORD

In recent years, Victoria has been working to develop and document processes for the management of major emergencies in Victoria.

The Victorian Emergency Operations Handbook summarises the operational management structures and systems used by agencies and government departments for preparedness, readiness and response to major emergencies in Victoria.

Although this handbook focusses on the management of major emergencies, the principles and concepts can apply to all emergencies in Victoria.

To achieve a coordinated response to an emergency, each agency must work together to understand the systems, structures, resources, capabilities and statutory obligations of the other agencies.

This handbook is an important reference for all those involved in managing major emergencies in Victoria. It is particularly relevant for those involved in Incident Management.

Consistent with an all emergencies approach, the handbook includes chapters on specific hazards, discussing factors that are unique and must be considered in managing them. This version includes State Emergency Management Plan (SEMP) changes.



Andrew Crisp APM
Emergency Management Commissioner

PURPOSE

The purpose of this handbook is to provide emergency personnel with a convenient reference to the key agency structures and systems required to undertake effective and safe incident management operations in Victoria.

It is important to note that the handbook is a subordinate document to the SEMP, procedures produced by the Emergency Management Commissioner (EMC) and to all other agency procedures, plans and manuals.

At the time of printing, the handbook is consistent with these procedures, plans and manuals. However, the overarching procedures, plans and manuals always remain the primary reference documents.

Part 1 of this handbook provides the overarching operational arrangements in Victoria for the management of major emergencies. The following sections provide hazard specific information with Part 2 describing bushfire related arrangements and Part 3 covering the arrangements for flood and storm.

PART 1 – EMERGENCY RESPONSE ARRANGEMENTS

EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT ARRANGEMENTS

Principles of emergency management

The Principles of Emergency Management underpin the activities undertaken by the agencies to address a range of hazards. These principles are not in priority order; they are all critical to the effective management of emergencies.

Primacy of life The protection and preservation of human life, including the lives of both agency personnel and those of the community, takes priority over all other considerations.

Community centric The community and individual community members will be at the core of everything we do. Focusing on the impact, outcomes and support to the community underpins decision making and actions undertaken in planning and responding to all hazards. The intent is to minimise the impacts of emergencies and enable affected communities to focus on their recovery as early as practicable.

Unified Working together to achieve common objectives as one team with the community, government and business before, during and after emergencies. Common goals and interoperability in our systems of work, doctrine, training, equipment and infrastructure.

Progressive Anticipation, foresight and continual improvement to predict, prepare, plan and respond to likely, unexpected and worst-case scenarios. Our actions have a positive effect that enable public value.

Risk driven Our actions and investments are prioritised by risk. Sound risk management, involving risk assessment (identification, analysis and evaluation) treatment and ongoing monitoring, is applied to the assigning of priorities and resources.

Integrated and collaborative Unity of effort towards achieving shared outcomes founded on a willingness to work together, share responsibility and act with respect, integrity and trust developed through teamwork and strong relationships.

Flexible Being agile and adapting and applying creative and innovative approaches in responding to and solving the challenges of emergencies. Understanding that the dynamic nature of emergencies sometimes means that plans will change and adapt to new circumstances.

Communicating information Providing clear, accessible and tailored information to those that need it and those at risk. This provides the basis for effective management of emergencies and better decision making through a shared understanding, accurate situational awareness and enabling the community, government and business to make informed decisions.

Victorian emergency management arrangements

The *Emergency Management Act 1986* (EM Act 1986) and the *Emergency Management Act 2013* (EM Act 2013) provide the legislative basis for emergency management in Victoria.

STATE EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT PLAN (SEMP)

The SEMP provides for an integrated, coordinated and comprehensive approach to emergency management at the state level. The EM Act 2013 requires the SEMP to contain provisions for the mitigation of, response to and recovery from emergencies (before, during and after), and to specify the roles and responsibilities of agencies in relation to emergency management.

The objectives of the SEMP are:

a. foster a sustainable and efficient EM system that minimises the likelihood, effect and consequences of emergencies; and

b. establish efficient governance arrangements that

    i. clarify the roles and responsibilities of agencies and

    ii. facilitate cooperation between agencies; and

    iii. ensure the coordination of EM reform within the EM sector; and

c. implement an 'all communities, all emergencies' approach to EM; and

d. establish integrated arrangements for EM planning in Victoria at the state level.

There are a number sub-plans for some hazards that provide specific information on the arrangements for managing these types of emergencies, these plans are available in Emergency Management Common Operating Picture (EM-COP).

STATE EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT PRIORITIES

The following state emergency management priorities underpin decisions during a response to any emergency.

Protection and preservation of life and relief of suffering is paramount. This includes:

- safety of emergency services personnel
- safety of community members including vulnerable community members and visitors/tourists.

Issuing of community information and community warnings detailing incident information that is timely, relevant and tailored to assist community members make informed decisions about their safety.

Protection of critical infrastructure and community assets that supports community resilience.

Protection of residential property as a place of primary residence.

Protection of assets supporting individual livelihoods and economic production that supports individual and community financial sustainability.

Protection of environmental and conservation assets that considers the cultural, biodiversity and social values of the environment.

In the context of protecting human life as the paramount concern, early advice to communities is as critical as operations. The Incident Controller (IC) may need to vary the state emergency management priorities in some circumstances. This shall be done in consultation with the Regional Controller (RC) and State Response Controller (SRC) based on sound incident predictions and risk assessments.

EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT FUNCTIONAL ARRANGEMENTS

Victoria bases its emergency arrangements on the management functions of control, command, coordination, consequences, communication and community connection, broadly described as follows:

Control The overall direction of response activities in an emergency, operating horizontally across agencies.

Command The internal direction of personnel and resources of an agency, operating vertically within the agency.

Coordination The bringing together of agencies and resources to ensure effective preparation for, response to and recovery from emergencies.

Consequences The management of the effect of emergencies on individuals, the community, infrastructure and the environment.

Communication The engagement and provision of information across agencies and proactively with the community to prepare for, respond to and recover from emergencies.

Community connection The understanding and connecting with trusted networks, trusted leaders and all communities to support resilience and decision making.

MAJOR EMERGENCIES

The EM Act 2013 contains specific definitions for emergencies.

A Class 1 emergency is either:

- a major fire or
- any other major emergency for which the control agency is the FRV, CFA or Victoria State Emergency Services (VICSES).

A Class 2 emergency is a major emergency that is not:

- a Class 1 emergency or
- a warlike act or act of terrorism, whether directed at Victoria or at any other state or territory of the Commonwealth or
- a hi-jack, siege or riot.

The SEMP also defines a Class 3 emergency (also known as security emergencies) as:

- a warlike act or act of terrorism, where directed at Victoria or at any other state or Territory of the Commonwealth or
- a hi-jack, siege or riot.

A Major emergency is:

(a) a large or complex emergency (however caused) which:

  - has the potential to cause, or is causing, loss of life and extensive damage to property, infrastructure or the environment or
  - has the potential to have, or is having, significant adverse consequences for the Victorian community or a part of the Victorian community
  - requires the involvement of two or more agencies (fire service agencies if a major fire) to respond to the emergency or

(b) a Class 1 emergency or

(c) a Class 2 emergency.

A Major fire is a large or complex fire (however caused) which:

(a) has the potential to cause or is causing loss of life and extensive damage to property, infrastructure or the environment or

(b) has the potential or is having significant adverse consequences for the Victorian community or a part of the Victorian community or

(c) requires the involvement of two or more fire service agencies to suppress the fire or

(d) will, if not suppressed, burn for more than one day.

Sections 37 and 38 of the EM Act 2013 prescribe specific arrangements for the Class 1 emergencies and fires other than major fires.

TIERS OF EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT

Victorian emergency management operates at three tiers:

- incident
- region
- state.

There is also the option for the EMC or Chief Commissioner of Police (CCP) to designate an 'area of operation' to manage a complex emergency that may be geographically located over several municipalities or several regions.

Incident Tier

The tier at which an emergency is likely to occur, is occurring or has occurred. In the response phase, it is most commonly the immediate incident area; otherwise the local government area.

Typically, in a Class 1 emergency, the incident tier will maintain tactical control and coordination for specific response activities (such as firefighting in a specified location) and relief and recovery activities (such as the operation of a relief centre).

Regional Tier

The tier at which there are specific EM arrangements for an area that is declared by the Governor in Council under the EM Act 2013 s77A. Figure 1 shows Victoria's regions:

- Barwon South West
- Grampians
- Loddon Mallee
- Hume
- Gippsland
- Southern Metropolitan
- Eastern Metropolitan
- North and West Metropolitan.

Typically, in a major emergency, the regional tier will provide the first level of assurance of control, coordination of response, recovery, consequence management, communications and resourcing.

FIGURE 1: VICTORIAN GOVERNMENT REGIONS



As the emergency escalates and the incident become more fully occupied with response activities, the regional tier assumes increasing responsibility for strategic decision making.

State Tier

The state tier is activated when resource requirements, coordination, consequences and communications extend beyond the region or area of operation tiers and need the highest level of management.

Typically, in a major emergency, the state tier will provide oversight and assurance of control, hight level coordination and coordination for specific response and/or recovery activities (such as mass evacuations). As the emergency escalates, the state tier assumes increasing responsibility for strategic decision making including the use of Cabinet, Cabinet sub-committees and strategic committees comprising of relevant stakeholders.

Area of Operation

A unique area designated by the EMC or Chief Commissioner of Police. It is commonly one or more municipal districts or two or more regions. For example, an area of operation may be:

- a number of local government areas
- across municipal boundaries
- established for incidents with far reaching consequences.

The EMC or Chief Commissioner of Police may determine arrangements particular to the area of operation. For example, the determination may include:

- specified phases (such as response or relief only)
- officers and team/group arrangements (such as relief and early recovery operations and road access operations).

It is expected that Area of Operations arrangements, when activated, would apply for the response phase of the emergency and would not extend beyond transition from response to recovery.

Regional and state tiers are activated where a major emergency has occurred or is anticipated to occur, such as where there is:

- a forecast of extreme weather or
- intelligence or information of any anticipated large-scale emergency affecting life or property.

Where emergencies can be reasonably expected over a period of time the regional and state tiers may be activated on a continuing basis.

Not all tiers may be activated for all emergencies.

EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT COMMISSIONER

Under the EM Act 2013, the EMC has legislated management responsibilities across major emergencies, except for security-related emergencies. Section 32 of the EM Act 2013 lists the primary functions of the EMC.

Section 33 of the EM Act 2013 gives the EMC the power to do all things that are necessary or convenient to be done for or about, the performance of the functions of the EMC.

Section 46 of the EM Act 2013 gives the EMC responsibility for the coordination of the activities of organisations, including agencies, having roles or responsibilities under the state emergency management plan in relation to recovery from all emergencies.

The EMC is accountable for ensuring the response to emergencies in Victoria is systematic and coordinated.

The EMC's accountabilities for major emergencies are to:

- be responsible for the coordination of the activities of agencies having roles or responsibilities in relation to the response to Class 1 emergencies or Class 2 emergencies
- ensure that control arrangements are in place during a Class 1 emergency or a Class 2 emergency
- appoint a SRC in relation to a Class 1 emergency
- manage the State Control Centre (SCC) on behalf of, and in collaboration with, all agencies that may use the SCC
- ensure that the Minister for Emergency Services is provided with timely and up to date information in relation to actual or imminent occurrence of events that may lead to major emergencies and the response to major emergencies
- be responsible for consequence management for a major emergency in accordance with the EM Act 2013 s 45
- be responsible for coordinating recovery under EM Act 2013 Div 5
- lead and promote the implementation of the Victorian Emergency Strategic Action Plan to the extent that it relates to the improvement of the operational capability of responder agencies

- where relevant, oversee the continuation of the operational reforms provided for in the fire services reform plan
- develop and maintain operational standards for the performance of EM functions by responder agencies
- develop and maintain incident management operating procedures for responder agencies
- coordinate data collection and impact assessment process
- provide advice to the Minister on any matter relating to the functions of the EMC
- issue guidelines in relation to community EM planning
- be responsible for the preparation of the SEMP
- consider any REMP submitted by a REMPC for approval
- provide guidance to REMPCs in relation to compliance with the requirements of EM Act 2013 pts 5 and 6A
- ask agencies to identify emerging issues and report on the effect and consequences of the emergency on their area of responsibility
- provide advice to the Premier and Minister for Emergency Services regarding a state of disaster declaration under the EM Act 1986
- perform any other function conferred on the EMC by or under the EM Act 2013 or any other Act.

Response coordination is undertaken at each tier though the Senior Police Liaison Officer (SPLO), Regional Emergency Response Coordinators (RERCs), Municipal Emergency Response Coordinators (MERCs) and Incident Emergency Response Coordinators (IERCs).

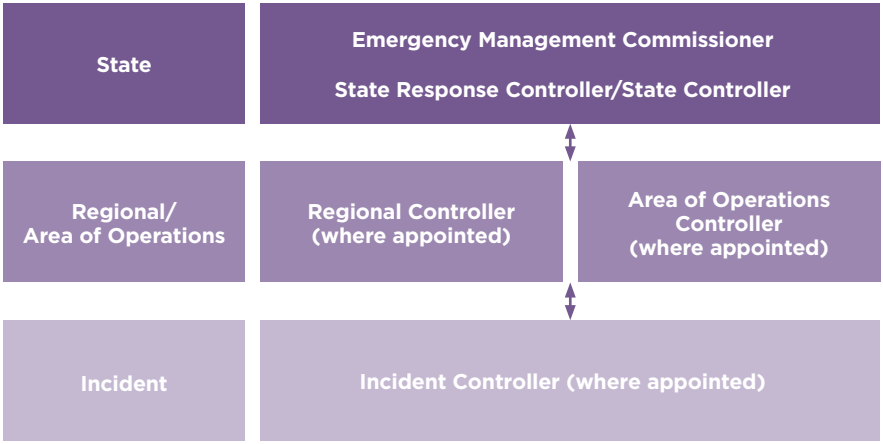
Recovery coordination is undertaken at the state tier by EMV, regional tier by Department of Health and Human Services (DHHS), local tier by local government. For communities impacted by the 2019-20 Eastern Victorian Bushfires recovery coordination, or as delegated by the EMC (BRV).

LINE OF CONTROL

Control relates to situations and operates horizontally across agencies. Controllers are accountable for the control of the incidents managed within their span of control and provide direction to all other agencies responding to the emergency.

The 'line-of-control' refers to the line of supervision for those appointed to perform the control function.

FIGURE 2: THE LINE OF CONTROL FOR CLASS 1 EMERGENCIES



Support for the line-of-control

For a major emergency, controllers establish the following support teams:

Incident Controller (IC) Supported by an Incident Management Team (IMT) and an Incident Emergency Management Team (IEMT).

Regional Controller (RC) Supported by the Regional Control Team (RCT) and Regional Emergency Management Team (REMT).

EMC and State Response Controller (SRC)/State Controller (SC) Supported by the State Control Team (SCT), State Coordination Team (SCoT) and State Emergency Management Team (SEMT).

Area of Operations Controller (AOC) (where established) supported by the Area of Operations Control Team (AOCT).

The IEMT, REMT and SEMT are forums where relevant agencies identify and discuss the risks and likely consequences of an emergency and assist the controllers to establish priorities and plan the actions of agencies to achieve a 'whole of government' approach.

Controllers at each tier of control need to have a process for recording their decisions and those of their support teams, and a process for maintaining and storing these records. The responsibility for this function may be allocated to the Executive Officer.

In anticipation of a Class 1 emergency the EMC rosters SRCs, Zone Controllers (ZC) and RCs throughout the year to ensure their continued availability.

For an incident that is a Class 2 emergency, the control agency may appoint a Class 2 SC who may in turn appoint RCs/ ICs as required and, if so, their role is like RCs/ ICs for Class 1 emergencies.

The EMC, SRC/Class 2 SCand RC maintain an overview of the emergency through contact with agency commanders. Their level of involvement in the management of an incident relates to the current activity or potential of the emergency.

Incident tier

INCIDENT CONTROLLER

The IC leads and manages the incident tier response to an emergency.

In first response to an incident, the control agency appoints an IC. The name of the IC should be included in incident reports and shared with the other agencies responding to the incident.

For an incident that is or that may become a Class 1 emergency the RC will appoint an IC, regardless of their agency, from a list of ICs endorsed by the EMC.

For a Class 2 emergency the Class 2 SC may appoint ICs as required.

As the control function operates horizontally across agencies, ICs need to communicate with all other agency commanders responding to the incident, including the agency commanders of their own agency resources.

All ICs for major emergencies in Victoria work within the line-of-control.

Further information on the role and responsibilities of the IC may be found in the SEMP.

For information on the appointment of ICs for Class 1 emergencies refer to JSOP 3.08 Appointment of Class 1 RCs and ICs.

INCIDENT MANAGEMENT TEAM

As the incident escalates in size or complexity, the IC may delegate some or all management functions of incident control – planning, intelligence, public information, operations, investigation, logistics and finance.

In summary, the IC and their IMT have several tasks to address if they are to successfully resolve the incident being managed. These include:

- build a picture of what has happened, what is happening and what is likely to happen
- decide what needs to be done and how it will be done
- prepare a plan that captures those decisions
- gather the resources necessary
- implement the plan and monitor its progress
- keep people and agencies informed of all these actions
- maintain records of their deliberations and decisions
- manage environmental impacts and consequences of the response effort
- initiate and support the relief and recovery efforts for affected communities.

INCIDENT EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT TEAM

For a major emergency, an IEMT should be formed and chaired by the IC. The IEMT supports the IC and focuses on managing the effect and consequences of the emergency.

If the IC is unable to attend, or there are several disparate emergencies within the municipality, the MERC (or representative) should form and chair the IEMT. The IEMT usually comprises:

- IC
- Agency Commanders (or their representatives)
- Community and/or business representatives appropriate for the emergency, noting that some may not be able to provide a representative at each tier
- Incident Health Commander (IHC) (functional commander of supporting health agencies)
- Municipal Recovery Manager (MRM)
- Emergency Response Coordinator (ERC)
- other specialist persons as required.

The IC will task support agencies or functional commanders to implement a strategy or to provide resources in support of these strategies. Support Agency Commanders then implement the allocated strategy through their respective command structures, and report back to the IC as to the success or otherwise of the strategy.

The IC includes the strategies and the actions of all agencies in the Incident Action Plan (IAP).

The effective operation of an IEMT relies heavily upon communication between agencies. The importance of an effective IEMT to the successful management of an emergency cannot be overstated.

Emergency Management Agency roles are detailed in the SEMP Roles and Responsibilities at emv.vic.gov.au/responsibilities/semp/roles-and-responsibilities.

Regional tier

REGIONAL CONTROLLER

The RC leads and manages the response to emergencies within a Victorian emergency management region.

RCs work within the line of control for their respective Class 1 or Class 2 emergencies. The RC needs to keep the tRC for Class 1 emergencies or the Class 2 SC informed of:

- the effectiveness of the control arrangements for managing the emergencies
- progress on developing and implementing consequence management plans
- the integration of relief and recovery activities with the response.

The RC may appoint a Deputy RC Relief where the scale of the event or prioritisation of response resources requires this.

REGIONAL CONTROL TEAM

The RC should establish an RCT to provide advice on a strategic approach to the readiness for and response to major emergencies. The RCT usually comprises:

- RC
- Regional Agency Commanders
- RERC
- Regional Recovery Coordinator (RRC)
- Regional Health Commander
- an Executive Officer.

The Regional Agency Commanders membership in the RCT will be based on the major emergency being managed at the time. The RC may request other people to attend.

The RCT provides advice to the RC in the following areas:

- readiness levels
- appointments to the line-of-control
- communication of warnings and information to the community
- operational and strategic risks and consequences, including those to life and property
- resourcing priorities
- provision of information and situation reports to other agencies and government
- the need for state support
- support for the functioning of the Regional Control Centre (RCC)
- the functioning and operation of systems and technology to support incident management.

REGIONAL EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT TEAM

If an emergency, either anticipated or occurring, requires activation of a regional tier response control structure, the RC will chair the REMT. In the event of multiple RCs appointed for several disparate emergencies, the RERC (or representative) should convene and chair the REMT. The REMT comprises regional tier representatives from response, recovery and other agencies.

The role of the REMT is to:

- facilitate a discussion to enable agencies to develop a consistent situational awareness regarding the emergencies affecting the region
- identify regional risks and consequences and plan the actions of agencies to manage these risks and consequences
- support the RC to develop a regional operational plan for the management of the emergency, outlining the regional tier actions of all agencies.

State tier

STATE RESPONSE CONTROLLER/STATE CONTROLLER

The SRC is the person appointed by the EMC to exercise control over the response to a Class 1 emergency. The EMC may appoint more than one SRC.

The SRC, when appointed for a Class 1 emergency has the powers and authority of the Chief Officer of the control agency, provided for under the control agency's relevant Act.

The Officer in Charge (OIC) of the control agency for the Class 2 emergency is responsible for appointing a Class 2 Controller. In practice the Class 2 Controller would be appointed at the state tier and would be known as the Class 2 SC. The SC is responsible for managing and leading the operational response to a Class 2 emergency.

STATE TIER GOVERNANCE ARRANGEMENTS

At the state tier, there are several teams that support the EMC in managing the respective coordination, control, consequence management and communication responsibilities in anticipation of, in response to and recovery from major emergencies.

The six key teams that operate at the state tier are:

- SCoT
- SCT
- SEMT
- State Relief and Recovery Team (SRRT)
- Emergency Management Joint Public Information Committee (EMJPIC).

The membership and role of these committees is set out in State Tier Emergency Management Governance Arrangements, Operational Readiness, Response and Recovery Activities 2017 v5.0.

Area of Operation tier

An Area of Operation tier is a unique area designated by the EMC or Chief Commissioner of Police. It is commonly one or more municipal districts or two or more regions and may be across regional boundaries or established for incidents with far reaching consequences.

The EMC or CCP may determine arrangements particular to the area of operation.

AREA OF OPERATIONS CONTROLLER

The AOC leads and manages the response for an Area of Operations.

AREA OF OPERATIONS CONTROL TEAM

The AOCT supports the AOC to manage the response to the emergency.
The AOCTcomprises of:

- AOC
- RC(s)
- RERC(s)
- RRC (if activated)
- Commanders of key support agencies.

Transfer of control

Establishing effective control arrangements in the early stages of the incident is critical. There are circumstances where an incident should be managed by an IC based in an Incident Control Centre (ICC) and supported by an IMT with specialist skills and equipment, rather than by a field-based IC.

These circumstances include where the incident is a major emergency or has the potential to become a major emergency, or where there is the need to do one or more of the following:

- issue warnings and advice to the community
- evacuate the community
- protect the community
- manage significant risks or consequences, for example to:
  - the community
  - community infrastructure
  - essential services such as electricity and water
  - the economy
  - significant environmental or conservation assets
- manage a large number of personnel and other specialist resources such as aircraft
- produce incident predictions
- implement health and safety systems for response personnel
- provide directions to multiple response agencies
- manage multiple incidents within close proximity.

SOP J03.15 – Transfer of Control and IMT relocation, outlines the process for the transfer of control from the field-based IC to an ICC based IC.

Once notified, the RC, with the support of the involved Agency Commanders, will source resources for the IMT. The IMT should be joint-agency (where possible), pre-planned and include personnel with relevant local knowledge.

For an incident that is or that may become a Class 1 emergency the RC will appoint an IC endorsed by the EMC. For a Class 2 emergency, the IC will be appointed by the Class 2 SC.

At predetermined triggers the EMC or SRC may determine all incidents within a defined area are to be managed from an ICC regardless of the size of the incident.

The following aspects are to be considered during the transfer of control:

- Field-based ICs and Agency Commanders should anticipate the need for the transfer of control in advance and notify the RC as early as possible to allow time for the ICC and IMT to be established.
- The transfer of control needs to be formal and recorded, with the field-based IC briefing the incoming IC at the ICC.
- The new control arrangements should be communicated to:
  - All incident personnel – consider issuing a Field Information Update.
  - The people holding key command and coordination roles at the state, regional and incident tiers of emergency response (depending on their level of involvement), with the expectation they communicate the arrangements to their agency personnel and support agencies.
- Incident management needs to be continuous throughout the transfer of control.
- Where possible, RCs should locate the IMT in an established ICC to minimise the need for further relocation.

Following the transfer of control, the previous IC will generally take on a role in the Operations Section, such as a Division Commander. They can then focus on coordinating field operations and providing information back to the IMT.

Where a major emergency can be reasonably anticipated (such as where there is a forecast for elevated fire weather or extreme weather), the EMC, SRC and RCs may pre-position ICs and IMTs ready to control emergencies that are or may become major emergencies. Refer SOP J02.03 – Incident Management Team – Readiness Arrangements.

Class 3 emergencies

A Class 3 emergency is NOT defined in legislation; however, it is defined by the SEMP to include, 'a warlike act or act of terrorism, whether directed at Victoria or a part of Victoria or at any other State or Territory of the Commonwealth, or a hijack, siege or riot.' These emergencies are commonly referred to by Victoria Police and the emergency management sector as security emergencies. They also meet the definition of a 'major emergency' as defined in the EM Act 2013.

A Class 3 Emergency sub-plan to the SEMP was developed to outline Victorian arrangements that deliver a coordinated response to Class 3 emergencies by agencies that have a role or responsibility during such events.

PLANS AND ARRANGEMENTS

A number of plans and arrangements contribute to the management of Class 3 emergencies within Victoria.:

DOCUMENT	DESCRIPTION
POLICIES AND PROCEDURES	Plans and standard operating procedures exist to govern the day-to-day operations within Victoria Police relating to incident attendance and emergencies. This includes the Incident Command Control System (ICCS) which governs how Victoria Police structures its response to emergencies.
EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT PLANS	Victoria Police will coordinate agencies to provide consolidated information to the community about required activities. Information is provided to inform people and support family and vulnerable members of the community. Community messaging will vary based on the location, type and duration of the emergency.
VICTORIAN GOVERNMENT COUNTER-TERRORISM FRAMEWORK	The Victorian Government Counter-Terrorism Framework ensures an integrated and holistic response to terrorist related emergencies. The framework recognises the unique nature of terrorist acts within the broader Victorian emergency management arrangements.

ANZCTC NATIONAL COUNTER-TERRORISM PLAN	The Australia New Zealand Counter-Terrorism Handbook contains nationally agreed guidelines, policies and procedures for police commanders, coordinators, senior officials and other decision makers involved in the counter-terrorism environment. It provides guidance on the procedures, structures and broad coordination arrangements for the preparedness, prevention, response and recovery phases of a terrorist incident. It should be used in conjunction with agency-specific plans and procedures at all levels of government.
VICTORIA POLICE COUNTER TERRORISM THREAT RESPONSE ARRANGEMENTS	The *Victoria Police Counter-Terrorism Threat Response Arrangements* identify key considerations and provide practical guidance for Senior Victoria Police managers when considering the organisational response to terrorism related incidents or threats (within Victoria and elsewhere).
ISSUES TO CONSIDER IN EMERGENCY RELIEF AND RECOVERY FROM AN ACT OF EXTREME VIOLENCE	This document, while not a plan for recovery from an act of extreme violence, supports the arrangements contained in the State Emergency Relief and Recovery Plan. The document identified issues and possible actions or mitigation strategies that are specific to the characteristics of an act of extreme violence.
OTHER PLANS	Other Counter-Terrorism Plans such as the Victoria Police Counter-Terrorism Strategy and the Victoria Police CT Handbook.

It is worth noting that there are also a number of structures and capabilities at the National level that support any State response.

EVENTS AND INCIDENTS

There are any number of planned events and unexpected incidents that could escalate to a Class 3 emergency:

PLANNED EVENTS	UNEXPECTED INCIDENTS
• Rallies, demonstrations and mass gatherings. • Industrial disputes/actions taken by unions or other groups that lead to mass gatherings and impact upon public order and movement.	• Active armed offender(s). • Incidents involving a hostage or hostages. • Rallies, demonstrations and mass gatherings. • Suspicious packages. • Improvised Explosive Device/Threats.
• Planned visits to Victoria by local and foreign dignitaries and Internationally Protected Persons (IPPs). • Major sporting, business, cultural and social events. • Counter-Terrorism operations.	• Hostile vehicle incidents.

CONTROL ARRANGEMENTS

The SEMP provision for agency control, with Victoria Police designated as the control agency for all Class 3 emergencies. The State Emergency Management Priorities should be taken into account when determining agency control during the response to a Class 3 emergency. For police activity related to a class 3 emergency, Victoria Police would normally undertake their management of this emergency at the State Police Operations Centre. The State Emergency Support Centre acts as an adjunct to the SPOC and is the facility where support agencies assemble to provide services and response activity support to the Police Commander.

The protection and preservation of life must be a primary consideration having regard to the agency most capable of retaining control, particularly where several agencies could potentially be the control agency, e.g. fire, power outage or HAZMAT event.

Where an event involves a Class 3 emergency which occurs simultaneously with a Class 1 or Class 2 emergency, Victoria Police will maintain control of the Class 3 emergency, independent of the control arrangements of the other emergency. In such circumstances control of the concurrent Class 1 or Class 2 emergency may be undertaken by a Deputy IC from the relevant agency supporting the Police Forward Commander with his/her overall responsibility for managing the emergency.

If there is any doubt to the control arrangements during a Class 3 emergency, a Victoria Police Emergency Response Coordinator (IERC/MERC/RERC) will assess the situation and make a de-termination as to the most appropriate control arrangements.

STATE CONTROL CENTRE (SCC)

During a Class 3 emergency the SCC can support the State Police Commander by:

- ensuring the SRC and SCT maintain appropriate situational awareness to support strategic decision-making
- providing a central point for engaging and sharing information with key external stakeholders including the SEMT
- coordinating consequence management and relief and recovery activities
- leveraging the capability of all agencies to support response, relief and recovery activities
- supporting delivery of community information and warnings that are timely and coordinated
- supporting operation of the State Police Operations Centre and State Emergency Support Centre.

CONSEQUENCE MANAGEMENT

Consequence Management involves managing the effects of emergencies on individuals, the community, infrastructure and the environment. It supports strategic decision-making before, during and after emergencies and its importance lies in its ability to support longer term decision-making following a major emergency.

Consequence management also supports community recovery. Under the EM Act 2013, the EMC is responsible for ensuring that the consequences of major emergencies in Victoria, including Class 3 emergencies, are considered and managed.

TRANSITIONING TO RECOVERY

While Victoria Police will coordinate the operations of all agencies during the response to Class 3 emergencies, the coordination of the relief and recovery activities will occur across each of the three tiers of response.

The transfer from response to recovery will be a joint decision between Victoria Police, and the relevant recovery coordinator at the relevant tier (State, Region or Incident).

A number of considerations will be taken into account to determine the point where response will transition to recovery, and include:

- The nature of the emergency and whether there is a risk of ongoing threats.
- The extent of impact on communities, which may determine whether a prolonged transition period needs to be implemented.
- The extent and known level of loss and damage associated with the emergency.
- The extent of emergency relief required by communities.
- Considerations regarding the resources required to be activated for effective recovery arrangements and continuity of services to the community.

SAFETY

Everyone has a responsibility for safety. Emergency activities are inherently dangerous and regardless of what systems or controls are put in place, emergency personnel may still face hazards. To maintain your safety and contribute to the safety of those around you, incident hazards need to be identified, risks need to be assessed and decisions made on controls required according to what is occurring.

Personnel will make judgments based on their knowledge, skills, training and experience. At incidents, the IC, assisted by a Safety Officer or Field Safety Officer, if appointed, also have a responsibility to manage safety.

Individual emergency service personnel who are working on the incident ground may be confronted by changing situations and should continually monitor the environment to identify the hazards and assess the risks as they apply to the tasks they are undertaking.

The control agency, through the IC, is responsible for ensuring they provide and maintain, so far as is reasonably practicable, a work environment that is safe and without risks to the health of all incident personnel, including responders, support agency personnel and contractors.

To help achieve this, personnel deployed to a major emergency should receive a safety briefing that includes known hazards and potential risks and any mitigation/control measures in place. The safety briefing is usually incorporated into the incident briefing and should be supported at handover at all levels within the chain of command.

REMEMBER: Safety is the top priority.

There are two components to managing safety during an emergency. The first component is the Safe Person Approach. The second component deals with assessing risk using a Dynamic Risk Assessment.

Safety first approach

In line with the state emergency management priorities the safety of emergency personnel is required to be given priority over all other considerations and activities. All personnel are to avoid putting themselves at risk when working at an incident. By adopting the Safe Person Approach (SPA) and using the Dynamic Risk Assessment (DRA) emergency personnel may minimise the risk of injury to themselves and others.

SAFE PERSON APPROACH

Under the SPA agencies have a responsibility to make sure systems of work are in place which allows work to be undertaken safely and, equally, personnel have a responsibility to ensure they work in accordance with agreed protocols. Each person has a responsibility for ensuring that their work practices do not result in an unacceptable level of risk to themselves or to others around them.

Safety is everyone's responsibility. Personnel should report all incidents and near misses and raise safety issues with their supervisor at the earliest opportunity. Doing so may prevent them or someone from suffering serious injury or even death at some time in the future.

REMEMBER: ALWAYS follow safe work practices and challenge those who do not.

DYNAMIC RISK ASSESSMENT

DRA (see figure 3) is a simple continuous risk assessment process that allows operational personnel to rapidly and effectively assess risk, to decide on appropriate actions and controls and ensure responder safety in the rapidly changing operational environment.

When assessing risk, responder safety is paramount.

DRA applies to all hazards associated with emergency response and operational activities and is carried out by all personnel from all agencies whenever there is an unexpected change to the plan or work environment. DRA is an intuitive thought process and is typically not recorded.

SOP J08.02 – Dynamic Risk Assessment outlines the practice of continuous DRA as a component of all operational activities, including emergency response and training, to ensure responder safety is maintained.

The DRA process is summarised below:

Evaluate – situation, tasks and persons at risk.

What is my task, what is going on and what are the hazards?
Determine the tasks and identify the associated hazards to determine the risk for the situation. Utilise information and available tools, such as call information, SMEACS briefing, WATCHOUT, pre-plans or familiarity with the conditions.

Select – systems of work

What do I plan to do and how do I plan to do it?
Consider the possible systems of work and choose the most appropriate for the situation.

Assess – the chosen systems of work

What are the risks of what I plan to do?
Assess the chosen systems of work and determine the associated level of risk. The acceptable level of risk will depend on a range of factors including the potential risk to responders and community, whether lives can be saved, value of the assets involved, cost of incident and the level of risk of proposed tasks.

Decide – are the risks proportional to the benefits?

Is my plan safe? Do the benefits outweigh the consequences?
Determine whether the risks of the tasks are proportional to the benefits by assessing whether the benefits of carrying out the tasks outweigh the consequences if the risk was to occur. When assessing risk, responder safety is paramount. If risks outweigh the benefits, then the task cannot proceed without further controls.

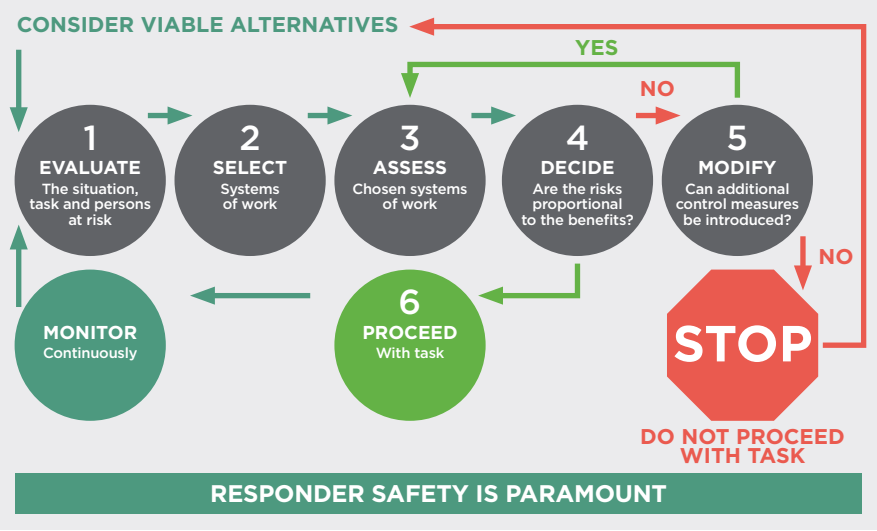
Modify – can additional control measures be introduced?

Can I make the task safer?
When the risk of the system of work is not proportional to the benefits introduce risk controls using the risk control hierarchy of elimination, substitution, engineering controls, administrative controls, and personal protective equipment (PPE).

Proceed with task?

As I proceed, what has changed and what do I need to re-evaluate?
If any risk remains, determine whether the benefit gained from carrying out the task outweighs the possible consequences if the identified risk was to occur. When assessing risk, responder safety is paramount. If the benefits outweigh the risks then the task can proceed. If the risks outweigh the benefits, DO NOT proceed with the tasks but consider an alternative system of work.

FIGURE 3: DYNAMIC RISK ASSESSMENT PROCESS





LACES

In some emergencies, on ground responders rely on the use of safety zones and escape routes for safety as conditions change. In these situations, LACES provides a system to maintain safety. Alternate systems of work may be available to manage particular risks encountered during emergency work. If an alternative system is not available, or is unsuitable, LACES should be considered as part of the Dynamic Risk Assessment process.

L	LOOKOUTS
A	AWARENESS
C	COMMUNICATIONS
E	ESCAPE ROUTES
S	SAFETY ZONES

The process for implementing LACES is:

LOOKOUTS

A fixed, aerial or mobile lookout shall be deployed to maintain a clear appreciation of risks and to provide timely advice of the need to use of escape routes and safety zones.

AWARENESS

Responders shall be aware of the impact of changes in incident behaviour including those resulting from variations to weather and topography and of other incident ground hazards.

COMMUNICATIONS

All responder crews shall follow the Communications Plan, communicate with your crew and surrounding crews to discuss and address safety issues.

ESCAPE ROUTES

At least two escape routes should be agreed and made known to all relevant personnel. The suitability of an escape route should be continually reviewed to ensure it remains effective.

SAFETY ZONES

Safety zones should be identified and made known to all relevant responders. Personnel need to consider escape time and safety zone size requirements that will change as incident conditions change.

Safety considerations

SAFETY FACT SHEETS

There are a number of safety fact sheets that have been developed across agencies and are available in EM-COP.

HYDRATION

It is important all personnel remain hydrated throughout their shift, especially during periods of prolonged or intensive physical activity. Dehydration will occur if fluids and electrolytes lost through perspiration are not replaced. The use of an agency approved electrolyte drink/powder is important to maintaining good hydration levels. The recommended ratio of water to electrolytes is 2:1. Depending on workload you should be drinking up to 1200 ml of water and 600 ml of an agency approved electrolyte replacement drink/powder per hour.

FATIGUE

Fatigue in both its acute and cumulative forms, can present a real risk to safety and performance at emergencies if not recognised and appropriately managed. The highest risks are to personal safety when associated with activities involving machinery and other equipment, including when driving motor vehicles after long shifts.

In addition to managing the fatigue of others within their sphere of influence, emergency personnel and incident management personnel need to actively manage their own fatigue, particularly in relation to driving vehicles and equipment and machinery use.

Agency personnel should adhere to existing agency protocols related to fatigue management and report any observation of Occupational Health & Safety (OHS) incidents (including near-misses).

ENVIRONMENTAL CONDITIONS

Incident Personnel need to consider the environment in which they are working. Conditions to consider include working around trees, flood water, weather such as extreme heat or cold, or strong winds.

Health monitoring

Health Monitoring helps mitigate health risks to responders and identify those who may be at risk of adverse health outcomes as a result of their response to an emergency incident.

It includes taking vital signs, and the assessment of presenting symptoms and relevant medical history to determine if a person's health is impacted by their involvement in incident response.

All personnel attending and working at major emergencies are strongly encouraged to undertake health monitoring to support their health and welfare, however health monitoring is not mandatory except in circumstances where the Standard for Managing Exposure to Significant Carbon Monoxide Emissions states that all personnel are required to undertake health monitoring.

Health monitoring may be provided by AV or approved private providers.

Please refer to JSOP 8.05 – Health Monitoring – Emergency Service Personnel for further information and the process for requesting Health Monitoring.

Communication of safety information

RED FLAG WARNINGS

A Red Flag Warning is a message issued when there is a significant change to any critical information that may adversely affect the safety of personnel located at an emergency. Further information can be found in SOP J03.11 – Red Flag Warnings.

A Red Flag Warning should be issued when there is, or is predicted to be, a significant risk to safety due to changed circumstances, including but not limited to:

- weather conditions
- incident conditions and/or behaviour
- equipment availability
- communications arrangements
- access.

A Red Flag Warning for a specific incident may only be issued by the following personnel, in their area of responsibility:

- Sector Commander
- Division Commander
- Operations Officer
- IC.

The SRC, RC, State and Regional Agency Commanders, State Duty Officer, Operations Manager, and the rostered Area or District Duty Officer may advise an IC to issue a Red Flag Warning.

Red Flag Warnings can be conveyed by any appropriate means. Red Flag Warnings, regardless of how they are conveyed, need to be preceded by the words, 'Red Flag Warning'. The message should be specific to the key audience (e.g. the Eastern Division) to minimise radio congestion.

Personnel receiving a Red Flag Warning are required to:

- Immediately confirm that they have received the warning.
- Repeat the key points of the warning (e.g. time etc.) back to demonstrate that they understand the warning.
- Notify all responding and supporting agency personnel and any other resources that they are supervising or who are reporting to them of the Red Flag Warning.
- Obtain a confirmation from the response and support agency personnel that they are supervising that they have received the Red Flag Warning.

An example of the process outlined in Figure 4.

Should acknowledgement not be received, a reissue of the communication containing the Red Flag Warning is to be undertaken.

FIGURE 4: RED FLAG WARNING PROCESS



STEP 1
For example, if the Operations Officer initiates a Red Flag Warning, they issue it to Division Commanders. The Operations Officer then advises the Incident Controller.

STEP 2
Division Commanders acknowledge receipt and repeat back the key points of the Warning to demonstrate understanding.

STEP 3
Division Commanders issue the Red Flag Warning to Sector Commanders.

STEP 4
Sector Commanders acknowledge receipt and repeat back the key points of the Warning to demonstrate understanding.

STEP 5
Sector Commanders issue Warning to Strike Team/Task Force Leaders and any others they are supervising, who acknowledge receipt (**STEP 6**), and issue the Warning to their crew members (**STEP 7**), who acknowledge the Warning (**STEP 8**).

NOTE: Red Flag Warnings are not a directive to leave the incident ground responders should consider local knowledge and situation when determining what action to take in response to the warning.

Any person, to Crew Leader level, who receives and/or forwards a Red Flag Warning are required to log:

- who communicated the Red Flag Warning
- the time it was received
- what information it contained
- how it was received (e.g. telephone, radio etc.)
- who you disseminated it on to
- the time acknowledgements were received from those you supervise.

If the repeated Red Flag Warning has not been acknowledged, the person sending the warning should take appropriate steps to determine the reason why the warning has not been acknowledged and report this to the IC or immediate supervisor.

FIELD INFORMATION UPDATE

The Field Information Update (FIU) is a method for the distribution of changes to strategy, tactics, new intelligence, safety information to the field during a shift. It is typically new information that was not included or available at the time of the briefing.

It may be delivered via radio broadcast or printed copy, and may include:

- weather
- incident behaviour
- organisation (sectorisation, control)
- communications
- strategy
- local hazards
- other issues.

Some ICs use it to structure messages to the field to update weather or advising that transfer of control has been completed and new reporting lines.

It complements the Red Flag Warning as a mechanism to broadcast more general information than the targeted critical information that is the subject matter of a Red Flag Warning.

A FIU does not require acknowledgement. The FIU pro forma is in the IMT toolbox.

OHS incident reporting

Emergency Personnel are required to report OH&S incidents to their OIC/Manager/Supervisor as soon as practical. All incidents are to be recorded in your own agency's hazard and incident reporting system or by using OHS Incident Card system (salmon card). All relevant sections are required to be completed and forwarded to the IC or delegate (Incident Safety Officer) where an incident is being managed by an IMT.

At the end of each shift it is the Incident Safety Officer/Medical Unit Team Leader/Logistics Officer's responsibility to ensure all relevant incidents from that shift have been recorded and relevant documentation kept.

Minor OH&S incidents are to be resolved at the local level unless otherwise advised by the IC. Blank OH&S Incident Report Cards are required to be made available to all emergency personnel and used to record all OH&S incidents where ready access to online systems are not available.

When a serious injury has occurred to a member, contractor or member of the public as a result of agency response activities the IC is required to be notified as soon as reasonably practicable. All serious OH&S incidents require the following notifications:

- Agency Chain of Command
- Line of Control
- Worksafe
- OH&S Executive Advisor

The IC is required to notifiy the relevant agency commander and this is required to be escalated through to the State Agency Commander. The notification will also occur through the line of control through to the IC, RC to the SRC and to the Emergency Management Commissioner.

When a serious injury, that is a WorkSafe notifiable incident, has occurred to emergency personnel, contractor or member of the public as a result of agency response activity, WorkSafe must be notified verbally within 24 hours by the home agency. Written confirmation on the approved form is required within 48 hours. Where an individual agency has notified Worksafe of a serious incident the agency is required to notify the IC as soon as practicable.

SOP J08.01 OH&S Incident Reporting and Investigation – Major Emergencies provides further information.

INCIDENT MANAGEMENT

Incident Management Systems

To ensure a standardised approach to incident management and so that responders have a common hierarchy to work within most emergency management agencies in Victoria utilize an incident management system.

The responder agencies and several other agencies utilise the Australasian Inter-service Incident Management System (AIIMS). Victoria Police operates its own incident and operational management model known as the Incident Command and Control System (ICCS).

AIIMS PRINCIPLES AND CONCEPTS

AIIMS applies to incident management, rather than to the region or state tiers of emergency response. However, AIIMS is based on principles and underpinning concepts that are universal and can be applied to the tiers of emergency management.

Principles

AIIMS is founded on five fundamental principles. These are:

1. **Flexibility** A flexible approach to the application of AIIMS is required. AIIMS is adaptable to an all hazards-all- agency environment. It needs to be able to respond to changes that occur with the evolution of an incident, both during escalation and resolution, and from a focus on response to a focus on community and agency recovery.
2. **Management by Objectives** A process of management where the IC, consulting as appropriate with the Incident Management Team and supporting agencies, determines the desired outcomes of the incident.
3. **Functional Management** The process of structuring organisation into sections or units based on the type of work to be performed. AIIMS identifies several critical functions that are required to manage an emergency incident effectively.
4. **Span of Control** A principle that to be applied in both the structuring and staffing of an Incident Management Team. The concept relates to the number of groups or individuals that can be successfully supervised by one person.
5. **Unity of Command** There is one set of common objectives for all those involved in the response to an incident, leading to one consolidated plan for all responders. Each subordinate should report to only one superior.

Concepts

There are several critical underpinning concepts that support the five principles of AIIMS. An understanding of these concepts is essential to the effective application of the system.

They are:

Adaptability and Scalability The size and structure of the IMT should reflect the size and complexity of the incident and the stage of the response and recovery.

Uniform Terminology If all agencies are to apply the system there needs to be agreed terminology and definitions, to enable effective communication between agencies and between members of IMTs.

Defined Management Structure In adopting a functional management model, there needs to be a clearly defined and agreed management structure that can be applied and understood by all.

Common Operating Picture A description of the shared and consistent understanding the IMT has of the incident, gathered from a variety of sources to support decision making.

Clearly Defined Roles and Responsibilities In defining the management structure, there needs to be a set of clearly defined and agreed responsibilities for all who are appointed to a role in that structure.

Clearly Defined Information Flow For a functional management structure to operate effectively, it needs to be clear what reporting relationships exist, and how the sections and units within the structure communicate to ensure the development and maintenance of the common operating picture.

AIIMS STRUCTURE

AIIMS provides a management structure for managing all activities to resolve the incident.

To manage an incident, the IC will establish a management structure designed to deliver the functions of control, planning, intelligence, public information, operations, investigation, logistics and finance.

By delegating functions to others, the IC creates an IMT. Delegation is the assignment of functions and tasks to others, together with the necessary authority, freedom of action, and resources to complete the task. The person delegating retains accountability but is no longer responsible for undertaking the actual task.

When establishing an incident management structure, it is important to remember that the incident determines the size and nature of that structure. The structure should be adapted to the circumstances being dealt with and reflect the complexity and scale of the incident.

The AIIMS functional areas most commonly used in the response to major emergencies are:

Control The IC has overall management of the incident and overall responsibility for the management of resources allocated to that incident. The IC is responsible for controlling the incident and ensuring that all incident management functions are undertaken.

Planning The Planning section is responsible for preparing and delivering plans and strategies, maintaining a resource management system, and assembling, maintaining and providing incident information.

Intelligence The Intelligence section is responsible for collecting and analysing data and information, which is recorded and disseminated as intelligence to support decision making and planning. The IC may choose to establish an Intelligence function within the Planning Section, or as a separate Intelligence Section.

Public Information The Public Information section is responsible for the preparation, coordination and dissemination of non-operational incident warnings and advice to potentially affected communities, the public, media, other agencies and incident personnel.

Operations The Operations section is responsible for managing resources allocated to the Operations Section to resolve the incident. The Operations Section now also includes a Plant Operations Unit, which aligns with current fire agency practice in Victoria.

Logistics The Logistics section is responsible for managing activities and resources necessary to provide logistical support during an incident. In major or long-term incidents with complex financial arrangements, the IC may elevate the Finance Unit to be a Section in its own right (in line with the principle of flexibility).

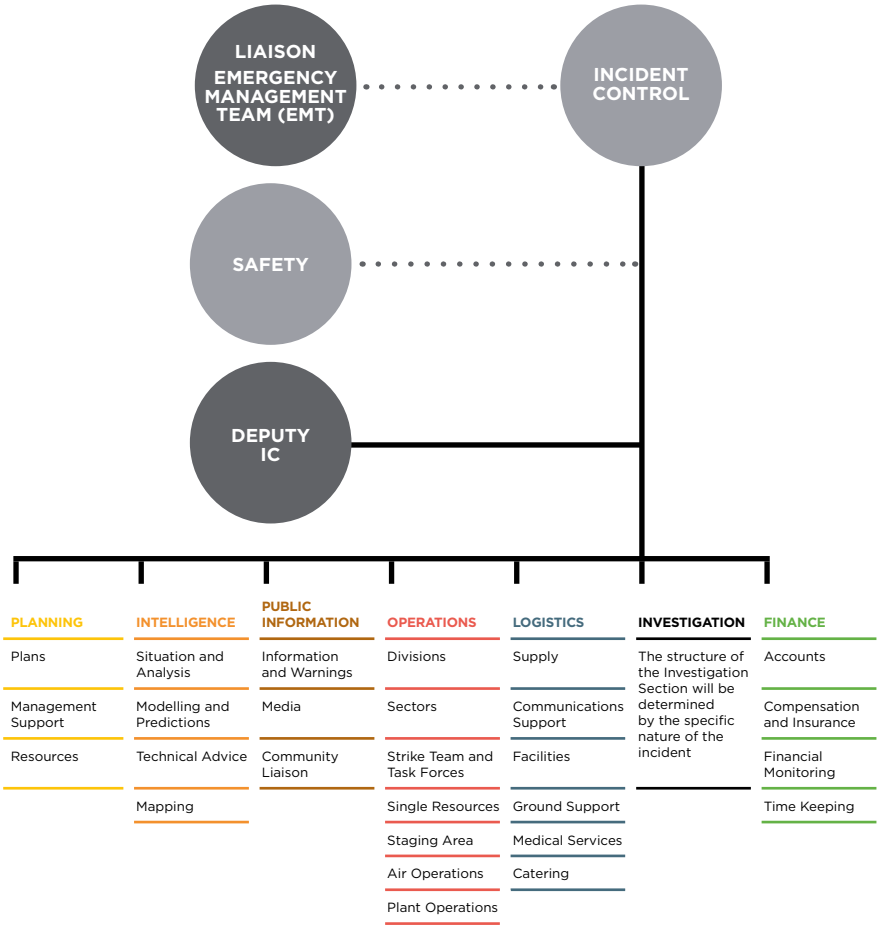
Investigation The Investigation section is responsible for conducting investigations to determine the cause of an incident and/or to determine factors that contributed to the impact of the incident or specific events.

Finance The Finance section is responsible for managing:

- accounts for purchases of supplies and hire of equipment
- insurance and compensation for personnel, property and vehicles
- the collection of cost data and provision of cost-effective analyses and providing cost estimates for the incident.

An example of the AIIMS structure established for a large incident is shown in figure 5.

FIGURE 5: AIIMS STRUCTURE FOR LARGE INCIDENT



Incident Controller

The role of the IC is to provide leadership and management to resolve the incident at the incident site. The primary responsibilities of the IC are to:

- Carry out the directions of the RC, where appointed, or the SRC or Class 2 SC, where appointed.
- Take charge and provide leadership for the resolution of the incident, including tasking supporting agency commanders.
- Establish a control structure to suit the circumstances and monitor its performance.
- Ensure timely issue of warnings and information to the community or refer these to the RC where appointed, or where the RC has not been appointed, the SRC or Class 2 SC.
- Identify current and emerging risks, or threats, and implement proactive response strategies.
- Activate relief arrangements through the MRM.
- Lead multi-agency planning and develop and implement an IAP (including objectives and strategies to manage the incident).
- Establish the IEMT, if required.
- Oversee the operational functioning of the ICC, if operating.
- Ensure the timely flow of information to:
  - RC (if appointed) or the SRC or Class 2 SC control and support agencies
  - MERC
  - IEMT
  - MRM/RRC
  - other stakeholder agencies.

- Continually assess the performance of the response against the IAP.
- Request appropriate resources for subordinates to achieve tasks or adapt tasks according to available resources.
- Initiate Initial Impact Assessment.
- Apply the EMC operational standards and incident management procedures, where appropriate.

All of these activities should be undertaken with consideration to the State Emergency Management Priorities and the Emergency Management Functional Arrangements.

Deputy Incident Controller

An individual/s may be nominated by the IC as a Deputy IC/s to support the IC in the management of the incident. A Deputy IC has responsibility for management of the Incident within the parameters agreed to with the IC.

The Deputy IC may not alter the incident objectives in the IAP. They may amend the incident strategies within the parameters provided by the IC. Where the Deputy IC does amend incident strategies, they are required to discuss the changes with the incoming IMT and IC at shift change over.

A Deputy IC who is appointed for a Class 1 emergency can be appointed to manage the hazard or to manage a function for example relief. Where appointed to manage the hazard, the person should be an agency endorsed Level 2 IC as a minimum. Where appointed to manage a function the person is required to be a person with the relevant expertise in the function e.g. recovery or evacuation.

Operations Officer

An Operations Officer, if necessary, may be appointed by the IC to:

- implement the strategies to resolve the incident
- manage all operational activities that are undertaken directly to resolve the incident
- manage all resources (people and equipment) assigned to the Operations Section.

Division Commanders

A division may be established in the early stages of an incident at the direction of the IC. The purpose of a division is to provide operational leadership and span of control over a functional or geographical area of an incident. The Division Commander has responsibility to manage the incident within the span of the division.

Typically, a division will be established when control is transferred from the incident ground to an ICC and the Division Commander will then manage incident ground operations from a forward location.

The Division Commander will:

- Report directly to Operations Officer or alternatively the IC (If the Operations Officer role has not been activated).
- Be accountable to manage the implementation of the IAP/Incident Shift Plan (ISP) relating to their division, and provide input to the IAP/ISP process managed by the IC.
- Have Sector Commanders (if appointed) reporting to them.

The Division Commander's responsibilities include:

- Maintaining ongoing exchange of information with the Operations Officer on incident situation, progress towards the achievement of incident objectives and emergency risks and reporting when:
  - the IAP/ISP is to be modified
  - additional resources are needed
  - surplus resources are available
  - hazardous situations are present and significant events occur.
- Ongoing liaison with the Intelligence Section/Unit to provide specific information on incident situation, progress towards the achievement incident objectives and emerging risks.
- Providing briefings/debriefings to Sector Commanders within the division.
- Reviewing, allocating and modifying specific tasks in relation to their division.
- Resolving identified logistics problems.
- Reporting to the Operations Officer.

- Observing safe work practices at the incident within the division.
- Coordinating activities with adjacent divisions.
- Maintaining a log of activities.

As an incident escalates the IC/Operations Officer may deploy additional staff to support the Division Commander in these functions.

Sector Commanders

Sector Commanders report to the Division Commander (or Operations Officer if a Division Commander is not appointed). Their responsibilities include:

- Implementation of their portion of the IAP/ISP.
- The allocation of resources within their sector.
- Reporting on incident situation, the progress of operations, emerging risks and the status of resources within the sector.

Sector Commanders will be advised of the incident objectives and strategy for their sector by the Operations Officer or their Division Commander (if appointed). The selection of actual tactics to implement the strategy will usually be determined by the Sector Commander. Tactics applied in one sector may, however, affect other sectors. Division Commanders (or the Operations Officer if a division is not established) provide the continuity of tactical operations across Sectors.

Incident objective

An objective is critical for the effective management of an incident. The objective should communicate clearly to all those involved what is to be achieved. A well worded objective has meaning and provides direction for every person at an incident.

The IC has responsibility for the control of the incident and sets the objective. It will state what the IC wants done, when and why. The objectives need to also be consistent with the state emergency management priorities.

The objective may change with circumstances. There may be a different objective for each shift under escalating circumstances or a static but relevant objective for a stable or de-escalating incident.

A good objective will include a statement of intent (what and why), a time parameter (when) and a space parameter (where).

Example of a good incident objective:

‘To protect residential buildings by containing the fire in the grassland as it emerges from the bush to the west of Bolton by 2000hrs today.’

Consistent with the above, management theory and practice suggests that an objective should be SMART:

S	SPECIFIC
M	MEASURABLE
A	ACHIEVABLE
R	RELEVANT
T	TIME-FRAMED

At the end of each shift, it is desirable that the IC and IMT review progress against their stated objectives and evaluate the effectiveness of the strategies implemented during the shift. This information can help an incoming shift to review and implement the new IAP and agreed strategies.

Incident action planning

Incident Action Planning should be aligned with the state emergency management priorities.

For an emergency with low potential, expected to be contained in less than four hours and/or of low consequence an IAP may be recorded as a log book entry or a situation report or wordback, either written or by radio, with comment on control strategy.

For an emergency that is not expected to be contained within four hours of reporting and/or has medium to high potential and consequence, the following are required:

- an IAP summary, documented within four hours of the incident being reported
- a documented IAP is required for major emergencies
- an Incident Shift Plan (ISP) that addresses as a minimum the next operational shift. The plan should include the tour of duty for the IMT and the duration of the incident to its conclusion.

The ISP is the component of the IAP relevant to field operations. ISP word templates are available on the IMT tool box.

The IAP should be communicated to personnel at the incident, especially any targeted information for specific Divisions/Sectors/Areas and those communications logged.

Where changes are made to an IAP, the IC is required to ensure that the information is communicated to all incident personnel. Significant changes such as change in strategy, tactics, communications, weather etc. should be communicated via briefings, Field Information Updates or Red Flag Warnings.

See table 1 for descriptors of the different components of Incident Action Planning.

Incident communications planning

The IC is required to ensure the development, implementation and regular review of the integrated Incident Communications Plan as required. This plan will be developed by the Incident Communications Planning Officer on behalf of the IC and needs to consider the following for all incident personnel:

- information and communications technology applications
- radio channels, talk groups, radio trunk numbers
- interference issues associated with channel selection across geographical area including aircraft interference
- adjacent ICC that may need to coordinate communications to reduce interference
- telephone number (including mobile and satellite phones)
- fax number/email
- paging
- redundancy options
- addresses known communications black spots.

An Incident Communications Plan needs to be incident-based, not agency-based. The IC needs to ensure that the communications plan is conveyed to all incident personnel and is conveyed in written form to all command personnel as soon as practicable.

TABLE 1: INCIDENT ACTION PLANNING DESCRIPTORS

DOCUMENT	CONTENT	TIMEFRAME	INPUT FROM	APPROVAL
Incident Action Plan (IAP) Summary	A concise IAP format. It summarises the incident situation, incident objective, strategies adopted, incident structure and communications Plan, and is supported with a map. It may also include resources deployed and key information regarding administration, logistics, command and communication and safety.	Completed in first 4 hours (may be replaced by ISP or IAP as developed).	Planning Officer (Duty Officer if IMT not in place).	IC
Incident Action Plan (IAP)	The plan used to describe the incident objectives, strategies, structures, resources and other information relevant to the control of the incident. It includes an ISP and other relevant documentation.	Within the first shift and reviewed each shift. Key elements may not change for duration of event.	Planning Officer Intelligence Officer Logistics Officer Operations Officer Public Information Officer	IC
Incident Shift Plan (ISP)	The key components of the IAP that are essential for field operations. The documentation follows the SMEACS briefing format, and is accompanied by maps and any other supporting documentation relevant to field operations (an interactive module is available on Fireweb).	Within the first shift and reviewed each shift	Planning Officer Intelligence Officer Logistics Officer Operations Officer Public Information Officer	IC

Communicating incident information

BRIEFINGS

The IC needs to ensure that all emergency personnel are provided with appropriate briefings regarding safety-related matters, the incident situation, incident objective(s), incident structure, communications plan, and relevant resource information and tasking.

All briefings need to be in the SMEACS format (see table 2) and allow time for questions after the briefing.

The IC is required to ensure that the appropriate information is efficiently communicated through the incident structure to emergency personnel. This may be achieved through:

- targeting briefings towards a specific audience, e.g. Division Commanders, and then cascading the briefing down through the incident structure as appropriate
- staggering the IMT and field changeovers to facilitate briefings.

As the situation changes and new information becomes available, updated briefings need to be provided throughout the incident structure.

All incident personnel have a responsibility to ensure they are briefed and understand their tasks before they commence their task.

SITUATION REPORTING

Those in a leadership position are required to provide frequent, concise situation reports (SITREPs).

Those on the incident ground (e.g. Crew Leaders) need to recognise that it is an important part of their role to provide SITREPs to their supervisor.

SITREPs should include the following information:

- incident name
- division command call sign
- location of incident
- potential of incident to become a major emergency
- advice regarding any warnings that should be provided to the community
- private and community assets at risk, critical community issues
- incident status (type/size)
- damage and loss
- critical control factors
- change in incident prognosis If bushfire – fire behaviour (e.g. fuel type and hazard rating, wind speed and direction, flame height and estimated forward rate of spread)
- current control objective
- resources on scene
- additional assistance required
- potential safety hazards on incident ground (e.g. asbestos, tree hazard, mine shafts etc.).

TABLE 2: SMEACS BRIEFING FORMAT

SITUATION	• Current situation. • Details of incident. • Operational Risk and Impacts to incident personnel. • Community Risk and Impacts – Incident risk and impacts. to the community. • Location.
MISSION	• What are we trying to achieve? • Incident objectives.
EXECUTION	• How do we plan to achieve objectives? • Sectorisation. • Strategies. • Tactics. • Tasking. • Resource movement details. • Timings.
ADMINISTRATION	• Logistics of operation.
COMMAND/ COMMUNICATIONS	• Incident management structure. • Communications plan. • Radio channels. • Strategic Relevant telephone numbers.
SAFETY	• Weather. • Known/anticipated hazards. • PPC/PPE. • Tasking suited to personnel.
QUESTIONS	

Emergency management locations

Emergency response facilities are named based on the function they support e.g. control centre, command centre, coordination centre etc.

The level of activation of a facility could range from a single workstation to a full centre facility, with escalation according to the nature and scale of the emergency.

Class 1 and some types of Class 2 emergencies are managed from the SCC, RCC and either an ICC, mobile command vehicle, site office or other location determined by the EMC. Class 2 and other emergencies, depending on the size, type and nature may be managed from an agency specific location.

Agencies may maintain their own command centres.

STATE CONTROL CENTRE

The SCC is the state's primary control centre for management of Class 1 and some Class 2 emergencies; it is the hub of a network of RCCs, which support the ICCs.

To meet the State Emergency Management Priorities, the purpose of the SCC is to:

- Ensure that the EMC and the SCT maintain appropriate situational awareness to support strategic decision making.
- Engage with and provide information to key stakeholders and SEMT.
- Ensure that readiness arrangements are in place.
- Ensure that control strategies and arrangements are appropriate.
- Ensure that incident progression is predicted.
- Ensure information and community warnings are timely and appropriate.
- Prioritise the allocation of state and specialist resource.
- Provide support to state, regional, incident control and agency personnel.
- Provide relief and recovery coordination.

REGIONAL CONTROL CENTRES

An RCC is a facility that enables the implementation of the Command, Coordination and Control arrangements within a set Regional boundary.

INCIDENT CONTROL CENTRES

An ICC is the location where the IC and the IMT manages response activities. A Level 3 ICC is a facility used to accommodate an IMT during preparation for, or response to, a major emergency.

DIVISION COMMAND POINTS

A Division Command Point (DCP) is a location where the person in the role of Division Commander operates.

A DCP could be a mobile point close to the incident ground in a field command vehicle (FCV), or a building such as a Local Command Facility (LCF) these may include local unit headquarters, district office or brigade station. An LCF has resources and facilities maintained to a level so it can be used as a DCP when required.

STAGING AREA

A staging area is a location designated and used during an emergency for the assembly of control and support agency resources prior to deployment.

All ICs should identify the location where incoming resources meet and are briefed prior to deployment to the incident.

Where more than ten resources are en route to an incident and/or the size or duration of the incident is likely to make effective control of incoming resources difficult, the IC should establish a more formal staging area, managed by a Staging Area Manager within the Operations Section. A staging area should also be established whenever a Division Command Point is in place.

When determining the location of a staging area, the IC should consider the influence of changing incident conditions (e.g. predicted wind change) to ensure the safety of incoming resources.

Local knowledge

Local knowledge has proven to be a vital element of effective management of emergency incidents. Whether it is the detail of an urban building, access to airports, history of previous emergencies or information on local business or industry local knowledge has proven invaluable.

Within every IMT, there needs to be a source of local knowledge, either a local person brought into the IMT specifically for that purpose or appointing local personnel to an IMT position where they can use that knowledge and answer questions from other members of the IMT. Local knowledge will assist IMTs in managing risks and consequences associated with the incident.

Ideally, those with local knowledge will be operating in the Operations Section to assist those responding to operations on the incident ground. Their familiarity with the incident ground, and perhaps the type of incident or previous incidents, will also be of benefit to the Planning Section, Intelligence Section or Unit as it considers risks, options and likely courses of action. Regardless of where the individuals are located within the IMT, the IC needs to be satisfied that there is sufficient local knowledge in the IMT.

ABORIGINAL CULTURAL HERITAGE PROTECTION AND REHABILITATION

Aboriginal cultural heritage in a variety of forms is present throughout the whole of Victoria. Ensuring that there are adequate and consistent processes for the management and protection of Aboriginal cultural values during an emergency is important at all stages of preparedness, incident management and relief and recovery.

It should be an integral part of an emergency management response to try and avoid, or minimize, impacts on Aboriginal cultural heritage wherever possible. Where impacts have occurred, it is important that these are fully documented, and the information is provided to Aboriginal Victoria. It is important to ensure cultural heritage protection works carried out during an incident are appropriately communicated through to the recovery phase of an incident.

Examples of Aboriginal cultural heritage that might be encountered or impacted by emergency management are:

- stone artefacts scatters or isolated artefacts
- scarred trees
- rock art
- stone quarries
- shell middens
- mounds
- grinding grooves
- stone arrangements
- burials.

Limited information on Aboriginal cultural values can be accessed in the Aboriginal Cultural Heritage data layer through eMap and used by an IC, IMT Planning Officer or other relevant roles in an IMT. General information on various Aboriginal places and objects can also be found on EM-COP (fact sheets).

If an initial assessment indicates that there is a risk of impacts to Aboriginal cultural heritage, it may be necessary to seek specialist, expert advice on the interpretation of this data. A list of specialist Aboriginal Cultural Heritage Values Advisors from Aboriginal Victoria, Parks Victoria or Department of Environment, Land, Water and Planning (DELWP) and their contact details can be found on EM-COP.

An Aboriginal Cultural Heritage Values Advisor could be deployed to an IMT and provide advice, as well as assisting with liaison with the relevant Registered Aboriginal Party (RAP), or any other identified Traditional Owner groups where a RAP has not been appointed.

Information about the location and nature of Aboriginal cultural heritage is sensitive and any data provided must only be used for of emergency management. After an incident, all hard copies of data must be returned to the Aboriginal Cultural Heritage Values Advisor (if one was deployed), Aboriginal Victoria and securely stored in any official files or records associated with the management of the incident.

Aircraft and aviation

The State Air Desk (SAD) operates as a function of the SCC and coordinates the operational emergency aviation activity within the state for response activities under the control of the EMC/SRC. The SAD also supports land management activities. The SAD is supervised daily by the rostered State Aircraft Coordinator to coordinate and, where appropriate, dispatch state aviation resources to assist with emergency and land management activities.

The Interagency Aviation Operating Procedures (IAOPs) are the procedures that govern the operation of aircraft for emergencies and land management activities. These procedures are produced to ensure the safety and effectiveness of agency aircraft operations by providing one source of agreed procedures which are available and relevant for all agency aircraft operations.

The SAD will only action requests for aircraft that are made by an agency person performing an approved role as stated in the relevant IAOP. AM 1.05 – Management of Aircraft at Incidents and IAOP AM 1.06 – Obtaining Aircraft. These procedures have been developed to provide specific requirements for obtaining aircraft for fire and non-fire emergency operations or other agency-related operations.

Aircraft deployments will be most efficient when approved personnel requesting aircraft provide the following initial information:

- location of the incident (i.e. distance and direction from closest town)
- aircraft type and quantity required
- tasking of aircraft and equipment required
- dispatch, incident or fireground channel and/or trunk radio numbers to be used
- AIIMS roles (Air Operations Unit) that are in place i.e. Air Attack Supervisor, Aircraft Officer.

Once dispatched, the aircraft are assigned to the incident and come under the control of the respective IC.

SOP J02.06 Aviation Resource Readiness outlines the readiness levels of aviation resources.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

Provision of warnings to the community

To protect life and property, timely, relevant and tailored warnings and information must be issued to potentially affected communities.

The IC (or agency authorising officer) is responsible for authorising all warnings and information provided to the public. To assist the rapid communication of warnings and information, the IC may authorise a Deputy IC or Public Information Officer (PIO) to authorise the release of warnings and information to the community. No additional authorisation is required once the IC or delegate has authorised the information or warning.

For warning content, technical advice may be sought from the relevant authorising authority. This may include oversight from Chief Health Officer, Chief Veterinary Officer or other Chief Technical Officers as relevant to the emergency.

Where an extreme and imminent threat to life exists and it is not practicable to obtain authorisation from the IC in the circumstances, warnings may be initiated by any response agency personnel. The IC is required to be advised as soon as possible.

WARNING CONTINGENCY PROCESS

In rapidly developing incidents, or if an Information and Warnings Officer cannot publish a message, the IC, or delegate, should request assistance from the Warnings Duty Officer at State level (24/7 backup to field-based Information and Warnings Officers) on 1800 877 990.

Warning levels and templates

Warning templates provide the IC and Public Information Section personnel the opportunity to include targeted information and specific actions for the communities affected. Warnings should be tailored to the community and reflect the impacts the hazard is having or may have on the community. This includes information such as road closures, the direction the emergency is moving in, where the community should go and information about what the community might see or experience.

LEVELS OF COMMUNITY WARNINGS AND INFORMATION

The following levels of warnings and information are used for multiple hazards. Examples are shown in table 3 below:

TABLE 3: LEVELS OF WARNINGS AND INFORMATION

ADVICE		An incident is occurring or has occurred in the area and you need to access information and monitor conditions. An All Clear when activity in the area has subsided and is no longer a danger to you.
WARNING/ WATCH AND ACT		Conditions are changing and you need to start taking action now to protect your life and your family. An emergency is developing nearby. You need to take action now to protect yourself and others.
EMERGENCY WARNING		The is the highest level of warning. You are in imminent danger and need to take action immediately. You will be impacted.
PREPARE TO EVACUATE /EVACUATE NOW/SAFE TO RETURN		An evacuation is recommended or procedures are in place to evacuate.
COMMUNITY INFORMATION		A notification that an incident has occurred but there is no threat to the community. Can also be where significant community interest is resulting in call outs or calls to ESTA.

ALL CLEAR MESSAGES

An All Clear message is to be issued to inform the community that they can return to normal activity that the risk is over.

An 'All Clear' message needs to be issued whenever a Warning (Watch and Act) or Emergency Warning or has been issued. An All Clear – Safe to Return is required to be issued if Evacuation warnings have been issued.

COMMUNITY INFORMATION

Community Information is used to provide the community with information if an incident is creating community interest but does not pose a threat to the community.

PUBLISHING WARNING AND INFORMATION AREAS (POLYGON)

Warnings and information issued to the community will have the warning area (polygon) shown on the map published to the VicEmergency website and app. ICs should ensure that the polygon associated with the warning or information captures the community who needs to act.

Community meetings

So that local communities feel supported and informed, it is important to engage in two-way interaction to help foster community connection. The PIO can provide advice on the best ways to engage the impacted community.

One key way of engaging the community is through community meetings. It is important to ensure that any community meetings planned:

- Are led by people with local knowledge, preferably people who are trusted by the community.
- Are structured for two way conversations.
- Use the tools available to properly record issues raised by community members, so you can respond.
- Outcomes from the meeting should be reported to the Incident, Regional and State tiers to add to situational awareness.

Community meetings should be streamed on Facebook or recorded and uploaded to social media after the meeting. This provides community members who cannot travel to the meeting a chance to still receive information (This includes those impacted by road blocks, who have disabilities or who have carers responsibilities).

Warning channels

There are numerous methods for providing information and warnings to the community, which include:

- emergency broadcasters (designated community radio stations, ABC radio, local radio, Sky News). For Emergency Warning and Evacuation Warnings, the Standard Emergency Warning Signal (SEWS) can be played prior to the warning being read
- media releases, press conferences and interviews
- social media (Facebook, Twitter)
- VicEmergency website
- VicEmergency app
- email distribution lists (local communities and EMTs)
- community sirens
- telephone warnings – Emergency Alert (EA)
- billing address (both landline and mobile)
- location based (mobile only)
- VicEmergency Hotline (1800 226 226)
- community meetings and door knocks.

Community sirens

There are Community alerting sirens in 39 communities across the state.

A siren is triggered through the warnings platform with the issue of any Warning (Watch & Act), Emergency Warning or Prepare to Evacuate or Evacuate Now, unless otherwise requested by the IC.

The siren will sound for 5 minutes to indicate that a significant emergency has been identified and the community should 'seek further information'.

SOP J04.01 Incident Public Information and Warnings provides guidance on community information and warnings before, during and after emergencies.

TRAFFIC MANAGEMENT POINTS

Traffic Management Points (TMP) are set up at the direction of the IC, in consultation with Victoria Police, to regulate the flow of traffic into an area where an emergency has occurred, is occurring or has the potential to occur.

The purpose is to maintain the safety of emergency personnel and the public, as a result of an emergency. Travelling on roads during or immediately after an emergency can be particularly hazardous. Emergencies are not static and therefore the conditions of TMP may change over the course of and incident, and at any time.

SOP J03.10 Traffic Management outlines the process for the activation and ongoing monitoring and deactivation of traffic management points, including the appointment of a Traffic Management Manager, development of a Traffic Management Plan and associated forms.

Traffic Management Guidelines describe the agreed procedures for the operation of a TMP as part of an overall Traffic Management Plan, to assist in the control and management of pedestrian and vehicular road travel near an incident.

To facilitate entry into an area, a TMP will be assigned an access level (see table 4). The circumstances and groups of people who may be permitted access at each access level will be determined by the IC.

Public TMP access

To provide ease of access through Authorised Access – C and Authorised Access – D TMPs, people who are to be permitted access may be issued with an identifying wristband. Wristbands will be available to people at the TMP upon proof of identity relevant to the access level. Where identity cannot be proven at a TMP, wristbands may be obtained from a designated community location upon confirmation of identity (e.g. electoral roll).

TABLE 4: TRAFFIC MANAGEMENT POINT ACCESS LEVELS

RESPONSIBILITY AND AUTHORITY	ACCESS LEVEL	EMERGENCY STATUS AND RISK ASSESSMENT	ACCESS *	IDENTIFICATION OR AUTHORISATION
Control Agency	 **Emergency Services Only Access**	• Going/new • Designated area likely to be impacted by emergency • Access route blocked and/or danger of hazardous trees	• Emergency services or emergency contractors • Other emergency or essential services authorised by Incident Controller or delegate • Any person authorised by Incident Controller or delegate (this may include residents, accredited media, etc)	• Emergency unit • Emergency agency ID • Emergency agency contractor ID • Escort by fire unit (eg wet escort) • Authority of Incident Controller or delegate (eg private/temporary vehicle pass) • Agency Media Accreditation
	Restricted Access – B **Essential Services Assessment**	• Contained/assessed • Emergency impact no longer occurring • Access route cleared and danger of hazardous trees removed	• Access Safety Assessment Vehicle/s (to consist of Council, Department of Transport (DoT), essential services, to conduct road and infrastructure assessment as required) • Emergency services, as authorised by the Incident Controller or delegate • People other than emergency-agency staff for the purposes of urgent care and management of land, or other reasons as deemed appropriate by the Incident Controller	• Designated Access Safety Assessment Team Vehicle – details to be advised by ICC • Agency identification • Appropriate wristband and/or authorisation by the IC via the TMM
	Authorised Access – C **Residents, Media, Recovery Services – B Access**	• Controlled • Infrastructure, road integrity, essential services do not present hazard	• Residents returning to their homes • People providing recovery and relief services • Council or DoT employees or sub-contractors • Accredited Media • Business owners in immediate area • DJPR or DELWP staff or vets facilitating the treatment and humane destruction of injured animals • Individuals or groups delivering relief and aid to residents and animals	• Resident – driver licence, authorising wristband • Organisation ID • Agency Media Accreditation • Business owner – suitable identification
Road Authority	**Authorised Access – D** **Access Others authorised, e.g. employees – C Access**	• Agency no longer requires TMP • Road owner requires TMP to address road-related issues	• Employees working in specified area • People bringing food and supplies for people and animals	• Organisation ID • Authorising wristband
	Open	• Road owner satisfied that road-related issues no longer impact on road users	• Open to all • TMP removed and signed off by road owner	• Not applicable

Coroners Act 2008 Section 38 Restriction of access to fire area

1) A coroner or the Chief Commissioner of Police may take reasonable steps to restrict access to –
(a) the place where a fire occurred: or (b) a place reasonably connected to the place where a fire occurred.

2) The coroner or Chief Commissioner of Police may cause a notice in the prescribed form stating that access is restricted to a place to be put up at that place or as near as possible to that place.

* Incident Controller may authorise access for specific persons or groups and impose restrictions)

EVACUATION

Definition of evacuation

Evacuation is a risk management strategy that may be used to reduce the loss of life or lessen the effects of an emergency on a community, prior to the onset of, or during, an emergency. It involves the movement of people threatened by a hazard to a safer location and, typically, their eventual safe and timely return. For an evacuation to be effective, is should be appropriately planned and implemented.

In line with the State Emergency Management Priorities, as with all emergency activities, the main priority when deciding to undertake an evacuation is the protection of life.

Evacuation is a scalable activity in that it may be applied to individuals, a house, a street, a large facility (i.e. school or hospital), a suburb, a town or a large area of the State.

The evacuation process

There are five stages in the evacuation process.

1. Decision to evacuate.
2. Warning or recommendation to persons likely to be affected by an emergency.
3. Withdrawal of an affected community.
4. Sheltering of persons evacuated.
5. Return of affected persons.

A formal evacuation process does not prevent people in the community from making the decision to self-evacuate in the appropriate circumstances

Recommendation to evacuate

The IC is responsible for authorising and issuing evacuation messages to the community (either a warning to affected people that they need to prepare to evacuate or a recommendation to evacuate immediately). This decision, if time permits, should be made in consultation with Victoria Police, IEMT and other expert advice where available.

A recommendation to evacuate should only be made when it is expected to offer a higher level of protection for members of the public than other options and can be achieved without endangering response agency personnel.

In some urgent life-threatening circumstances, and in an effort to preserve life, the decision to recommend evacuation may be made by any agency representative.

In this circumstance the IC is required to be notified of the decision as soon as possible.

Where the IC decides to recommend that people should evacuate, the IC is required to immediately communicate this decision to the Victoria Police Commander (for implementation), through the line of control and agency chain of command, the IMT and to incident personnel/responders.

SOP J03.12 Evacuation for Major Emergencies, outlines the responsibilities, activities and forms that are required to be undertaken by the IC and Evacuation Managers.

The Evacuation Guidelines provides further information and guidance for conducting evacuations.

Roles and responsibilities

Table 5 sets out the roles and responsibilities of the evacuation process.

TABLE 5: EVACUATION ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

ORGANISATION/ ROLE	TASK
CONTROL AGENCY (IC)	• Consider and recommend as appropriate evacuation in consultation with Victoria Police Evacuation Manager, Health Commander and other experts. • Issue warnings, recommendations to evacuate and provide situation updates and ongoing advice that may impact an evacuation (including the dissemination of public information). • Activate emergency relief services. • Maintain ongoing liaison with Victoria Police once the evacuation process has commenced.

ORGANISATION/ ROLE	TASK
VICTORIA POLICE (EVACUATION MANAGER) (TRAFFIC MANAGEMENT MANAGER)	• Assist IC with the decision and warning stages if required. • In consultation with the IC and other agencies, where time permits prepare a plan for the evacuation. • Form and manage an evacuation planning team, made up of representatives of organisations who can assist at any stage of the evacuation (e.g. support agencies and service providers, traffic management related agencies, road authority etc). • Identify vulnerable persons within the potential evacuation area including those residing within potentially vulnerable facilities, those designated as vulnerable persons per the Vulnerable Persons Register and other vulnerable persons as identified by other agencies/services (local councils etc) as required. • Manage the withdrawal, shelter and return stages of the evacuation in consultation with the IC and Health Commander. • Source and manage resources to facilitate evacuation in consultation with control and support agencies. • Maintain ongoing liaison with IC for the duration of the evacuation. • Coordinate the establishment and maintenance of traffic management points. • Registration of evacuees (with Red Cross), utilising Register. Find. Reunite. • Where cross border operations are in place, liaise with the relevant state police or traffic management agency.
EVACUATION TEAM	• A team led by the Evacuation Manager that is formed to plan and administer the withdrawal, shelter and return phases of an evacuation. • The Evacuation Team is formed when time and resources permit and is composed of the Evacuation Manager, the IC or delegate and other stakeholders as required. This may include, but not limited to, the Incident Health Commander and representatives from DHHS and municipal councils.

ORGANISATION/ ROLE	TASK
AMBULANCE VICTORIA (HEALTH COMMANDER)	• Provide health and medical strategy advice to the IC and Evacuation Manager. • Manage the withdrawal and return of identified vulnerable people from health and aged care facilities. • Support the withdrawal and return of identified vulnerable people in the community as required.
SUPPORT AGENCIES	• Assist with the provision of resources to facilitate evacuation. • Provide support during the evacuation process, under the direction of Victoria Police.
MUNICIPAL COUNCILS	• Coordinate the provision of council resources as required. • Establish and manage relief centres as required and provision of emergency shelter. • Assist Victoria Police with management of traffic flow including provision of information regarding road availability, capacity and safety. With Municipal Emergency Management Planning Committees: • Develop and maintain Municipal Emergency Management Plans in collaboration with emergency services and land managers. • Assist Control Agencies with development and review of hazard specific Emergency Plans and associated community information. • Identify and document within Municipal Emergency Management Plans facilities where vulnerable people are likely to be located. • Coordinate and have local oversight of the Vulnerable Persons Register to support local planning. • Identify and document within Municipal Emergency Management Plans self evacuation strategies and locations that community members may assemble that are not identified relief centres.
DEPARTMENT OF TRANSPORT	• Assist, Victoria Police with management of traffic flow including provision of information regarding road availability, capacity and safety. • Maintain list of road closures (public information).

ORGANISATION/ ROLE	TASK
RESPONDER AGENCIES	• Develop and maintain hazard specific Emergency Plans. • Develop and maintain hazard specific community information (e.g. Community Information Guides, Local Flood Guides).
AUSTRALIAN RED CROSS (VICTORIA)	• Registration of evacuees (with Victoria Police) utilising Register. Find. Reunite (web based or paper based).
DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES	• Support municipal councils in provision of emergency relief. • Provide guidance to health and human services providers and departmental program areas to develop and review their emergency preparedness plans (including evacuation and relocation) in line with the Health and Human Services Policy *Preparing for emergencies: A reference guide for organisations in the Health and Community Services Sectors*, and associated Relocation, Evacuation and Sheltering Guide. • Coordination of emergency accommodation arrangements.
DEPARTMENT OF EDUCATION AND TRAINING, ASSOCIATION OF INDEPENDENT SCHOOLS OF VICTORIA, CATHOLIC EDUCATION OFFICE	• Development and maintenance of plans to manage evacuation of educational facilities including schools, universities, child care centres, etc.
LAND MANAGER	• Contribute to preparation of local and/or municipal emergency plans, with evacuation information, e.g. ensure linkage between public land management plans and Municipal Emergency Management Plans. Specific attention should be placed on the identification of locations on the lands managed where transient populations of people (non-residential) may expected to occur (festival, camping and caravan sites, tourism installations, etc). • Maintain access and egress. • Maintain temporary refuge and assembly areas as a place to gather people until and evacuation can occur • Provide relevant information to the IC and relevant emergency agencies.

Vulnerable people

During an emergency, or imminent threat of an emergency special consideration needs to be given to the safety of vulnerable people in the community.

Some people living in the community may be unable to activate their own evacuation plan and a small number who do not have a personal support network will require assistance to safely evacuate.

The Evacuation Manager (Victoria Police) will be required to identify (where records are available) vulnerable persons in the community and in addition, facilities that house vulnerable people.

Other factors that may be considered when assessing an individual's vulnerability include:

- lives alone and has additional needs and/or lives with an individual with similar or greater level of additional needs
- physical dependence
- inability to make an independent decision due to cognitive or other impairment, and/or geographic isolation.

VULNERABLE PERSONS REGISTER

Vulnerable Persons Register (VPR) contain lists of consenting people living in the community who have been assessed as vulnerable to an emergency because they are:

- frail and/or physically or cognitively impaired
- unable to comprehend warnings and directions and/or respond in an emergency situation
- unable identify personal or community support networks to help them in an emergency.

To access the list of vulnerable persons in the community, the Evacuation Manager will be required to access to the web-based VPR. The VPR is accessible in preparation for emergencies and in emergencies when an evacuation has been deemed necessary. It provides information on the location of the vulnerable person as well as any special requirements.

INITIAL IMPACT ASSESSMENT

Initial Impact Assessment

The IC is responsible for initiating and managing an Initial Impact Assessment (IIA). The Incident Management Team and Incident Emergency Management Team should work together to determine required metrics for decision making and validating the data.

Triggers to determine the requirement for IIA should be considered in accordance with the state emergency management priorities. Some practical examples include:

- injured/deceased persons (only Victoria Police are authorised to comment upon or release data relating to deceased persons)
- residential damage indicating displaced people
- damage to essential infrastructure (road, rail, power supply, water etc.)
- damage to facilities of community significance e.g. schools and hospitals
- identification of primary production impact and animal welfare requirements.

IIA arrangements are designed to allow for flexibility in their application as it often occurs in a dynamic environment and the circumstance of a particular assessment may require adaption. IIA data will be shared across the IEMT and nominated recovery role to ensure a seamless approach for the requirements of secondary impact assessment.

Dependent on the scale and complexity of the event the IC may:

- choose to use existing IMT and field based resources
- establish an Intelligence Section (if not established) and utilise field based resources
- establish a specific functional unit within the IMT/IEMT to support the IIA process. This may include appointment of a specific role to manage the task
- request additional resource/s to assist in conducting and managing IIA.

There are a number of systems and resources that support the collection information across the agencies including specific teams, ground observers and incident personnel.

Secondary Impact Assessment

Good decisions about relief and recovery programs require timely, accurate and progressively more comprehensive information about the impact of an emergency on affected communities. Such information is vital to plan and provide an appropriate, adaptive and evidence-based relief and recovery program.

For Secondary Impact Assessment (SIA) to commence, the IC needs to be satisfied the impacted area is safe for non-responder personnel to operate in. The IC is required to facilitate the transition from IIA to SIA. Coordination of SIA is the responsibility of the nominated recovery role.

See EM-COP library for the Impact Assessment Guideline.

RELIEF AND RECOVERY

Transition from response to recovery

The Emergency Management Act 2013 recognizes the importance of an integrated emergency management approach to drive improved outcomes and build a resilient and connected community. To achieve this relief and recovery planning occurs before, during and after emergencies.

The response to, and recovery from, a major emergency involves many agencies from across government. The people and agencies with roles and responsibilities for responding to emergencies work together in emergency management teams at the state, regional and local tiers to ensure a collaborative and coordinated whole of government approach.

Emergency relief and recovery activities integrate with emergency response activities and commence as soon as the effect and consequences of the emergency are anticipated. Relief and recovery coordinators/managers should be involved at all tiers and in all teams established to manage the emergency response.

Once emergency response activities begin winding down, recovery can be prioritised. The IC performs a key role in ensuring the integration of response, relief and recovery activities. Whilst the emergency response is concluding and where recovery activities need to continue, the arrangements for managing the emergency will transition from response to recovery coordination.

The SEMP specifies the arrangements for the coordinated planning and management of transition from response to recovery in Victoria.

The teams at the relevant incident, regional and state tiers should discuss and agree the timing of the transition. The recovery coordinators/manager s at the relevant tiers must be ready to assume responsibility and have the appropriate resources assembled prior to the transition. The community must receive continuous services during the transition and a phased transition may be appropriate.

Considerations regarding the timing of the transition should include the extent to which the following are addressed and transition should be delayed if:

- significant emergency risks remain
- the powers available to control agencies and response agency personnel (which may be available only during an emergency response) are still required
- the effect and consequences of the emergency are not yet known
- the affected community continues to require relief services
- recovery resources are not yet assembled and are ready to undertake their roles.

Emergency response coordinators are responsible for advising all agencies involved in the emergency of the termination of the emergency response. Response agencies may be required to continue working at the emergency following the transition, but as support resources for recovery managers and coordinators.

A schedule of transition actions required is included in the document 'An Agreement for Transition of Coordination Arrangements from Response to Recovery', which can be obtained from Regional or State coordinators, or EM-COP.

Relief and recovery coordination

The Emergency Management Commissioner has responsibility for the coordination of the activities of agencies following an emergency and ensuring that satisfactory emergency management arrangements are in place to facilitate the recovery from emergencies. This responsibility has been delegated to the CEO of Bushfire Recovery Victoria (BRV) for coordinating recovery associated with the 2019-20 Eastern Victoria Bushfires.

At the state level, Emergency Management Victoria supports the Emergency Management Commissioner in performing the Commissioner's relief and recovery coordination role. Responsibility for the coordination of relief and recovery at the regional and local levels sits with the DHHS and municipal councils respectively. BRV supports the CEO BRV in performing the delegated recovery coordination role at state and regional tiers.

Municipal councils coordinate the delivery of relief and recovery and the Victorian Government supports councils in fulfilling these responsibilities by establishing and coordinating all regional and state relief and recovery arrangements and activities.

Emergency relief and recovery public information sources

The VicEmergency website (emergency.vic.gov.au) is a single source of online information for Victorians on all relief and early recovery matters, across all emergencies. It can provide independent information on concurrent major emergencies, plus archive information on previous emergencies. The VicEmergency website is designed for mobile platforms as well as desktop computers.

The BRV website will be utilised for recovery information for major emergencies where it is determined that BRV will have lead recovery coordination role. Links will be established across websites to ensure seamless access to information.

The VicEmergency Hotline (1800 226 226) is a dedicated 24/7 hotline with surge capacity, to handle all relief and recovery queries (via scripts) and if established, queries can be transferred through to dedicated area centres.

INFORMATION SYSTEMS

Emergency Management – Common Operating Picture

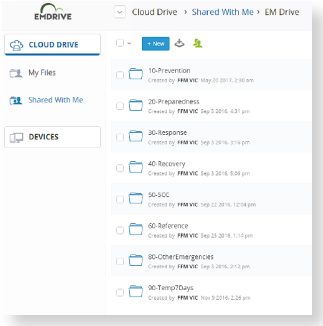
The Emergency Management-Common Operating Picture (EM-COP) is a web-based entry point for personnel across the emergency management sector to access information and systems using a standard web browser on any internet connected device.

EM-COP provides tabs for map-based collaboration, a global log, a desktop of links to current operational and other web-based information and a reference library. Access is via registered username and password and is open to all persons with a legitimate role in emergency.

To sign in, or to register, go to: http://cop.em.vic.gov.au (operations) or http://training.cop.em.vic.gov.au (training).

Emergency Management Drive

The 'EM Drive' is a shared cloud-based file storage available to emergency management agencies to enable personnel to create, share, manage and store operational information. Access is via a registered username and password using a web browser, allowing files to be downloaded for editing and uploaded back for others to reference.



EM DRIVE FOLDER STRUCTURE

Documents that should have a copy maintained on the EM Drive include, but not limited to, completed incident documentation such as:

- IAPs
- communications plans
- options analysis
- media releases
- photos
- completed/published maps.

The EM Drive is to be used for incident management purposes only. Personal documents or project related documents or project related documents should not be stored directly on EM Drive.

Separate areas can be set up for agency specific purposes.

For specific guidance on usage and business rules, particularly in relation to the 30-Response folder, refer to the library in EM-COP.

An icon to access EM Drive is available on the Operations page of the EM-COP desktop.

Emergency management webmail

Role-based email accounts are available for state, regional and incident tiers. EMwebmail is hosted in Microsoft Office 365 and uses a web browser to access mail accounts. The accounts are accessible to all agencies on all networks and allows agency personnel to access incident specific emails using any internet connect device.

When using EMwebmail it is critical that the appropriate mailboxes are monitored, and important emails followed up with a phone call to ensure information not missed.

Use the 'Subject' heading to identify the intended recipient(s) and the subject. Personal/agency email accounts are not to be used for emails relating to an incident.

Icons to access EMwebmail and login codes are available on the Operations page of the EM-COP Desktop.

There are also icons to a User Guide and a document containing descriptions and email addresses for all the role-based positions.

Resource requesting

The multi-agency State Resource Request System (SRRS) is designed to make it easy for Resources Unit members at incident, regional and state tiers, to submit and action requests for additional resources during incidents and planned burning. The SRRS is a requesting system only and is not designed for resource tracking.

All Resources Unit personnel, as well as those involved in the dispatch of appliances, should ensure that they are familiar with system. Access is via an icon in the Resources group in the Sections page of EM-COP Desktop tab, or by going to: https://fireweb.ffm.vic.gov.au/ResourceRequest/

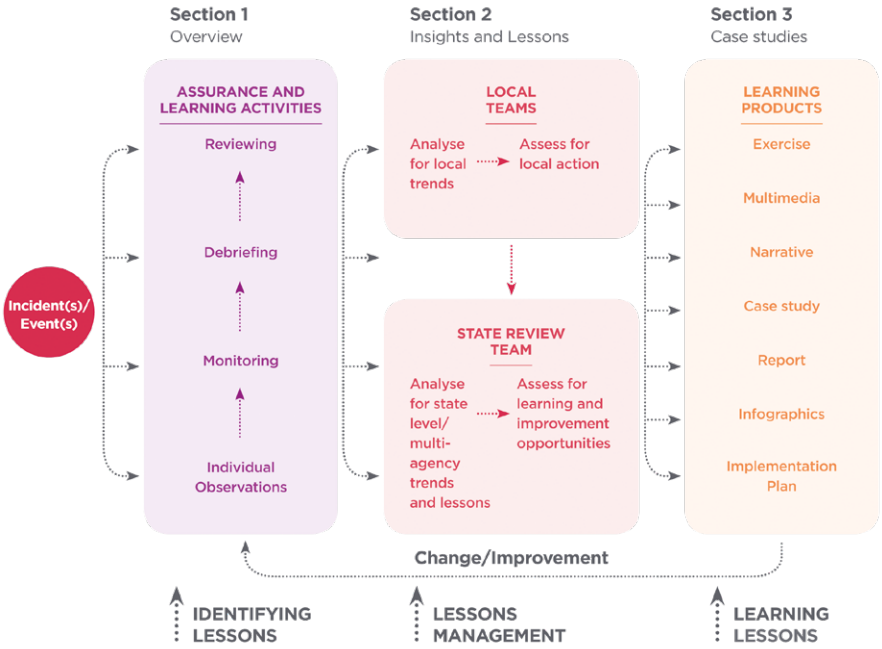
SOP J03.09 Resource Request Process sets out how to request resources for major emergencies.

LESSONS MANAGEMENT

The Emergency Management agencies support a culture of learning by:

- Utilising the EM-LEARN Framework (https://www.emv.vic.gov.au/how-we-help/reviews-and-lessons-management) and the Lessons Management Life Cycle to support the identifying and learning of lessons.
- Providing the opportunity to share experiences and learn from others.
- Encouraging the sector to share learnings about examples of good practice or areas for improvement.
- Utilising assurance and learning activities (monitoring, debriefing and reviewing) to identify areas to improve and sustain.
- Focusing on systems of work, rather than performance of individuals.
- Recognising that identifying and implementing sustainable solutions takes time, transparency, resources and commitment.

FIGURE 6 – OPERATIONAL LESSONS MANAGEMENT



Lessons are identified through collecting and analysing data from various levels, most often through individual observation capture and assurance and learning activities (monitoring, debriefing and reviewing). Lessons need to then be assessed for suggested treatments, determining appropriate actions with relevant personnel/teams/committees, allocating change/improvement activities and monitoring progress of implementation. Lessons are only learned once change/improvement is evident as a result of action, see figure 6.

Where possible local teams and governance groups (e.g. crews, EMTs, control teams, performance improvement teams, committees) should utilise the lessons management life cycle outlined in the EM-LEARN Framework to assist with analysing the outcomes of assurance and learning activities. This will ensure that locally relevant insights and lessons are identified, and actions are taken to contribute to continuous improvement.

The State Review Team (SRT) has representatives from the emergency management sector who hold the responsibility within their emergency management agency for lessons management. In addition to local analysis and action, the SRT, together with subject matter experts, identify lessons of state wide/multi-agency significance. These will be provided to relevant multi-agency working groups and committees for approval. SRT representatives are also accountable for the sharing of lessons identified within their agency and advocating for lessons management.

Consistent with the Monitoring and Assurance Framework for Emergency Management and EM-LEARN Framework, all assurance and learning activities should be guided by the following principles:

Learning focused Focus effort on learning and improvement activities that explore what went well and learning opportunities,

System focused Examining systems of work rather than individual performance,

Adding value Providing evidence-based information for the sector,

Minimising burden Using existing mechanisms to capture data where possible.

Trends-based Using multiple information sources to identify lessons (observation, insight, lesson (OIL) process).

Future focused Explore events to identify aspects to sustain and areas for improvement for the future.

Consistency Using consistent processes, tools and themes to enable trends analysis across events and experiences.

The outcomes of assurance and learning activities will inform the ongoing cycle of learning and improvement within the sector by validating and evaluating existing doctrine, arrangements, policy, procedure, and incident/emergency management application. The outcomes will provide evidence to inform a range of activities including training, exercising and briefings.

The list of SRT agency representatives and all documents referenced in this section are available in the EM-COP Library > Reviews-Lessons.

EM-Share

All personnel are encouraged to share their observations and initiatives to ensure the sector can learn from best practice and drive continuous improvement.

EM-Share is an online application that allows you to share your observations or files from operational and non-operational activities. An observation is a record of a noteworthy fact or occurrence that someone has heard, seen, noticed or experienced as an opportunity for improvement or an example of good practice. This is particularly important where personnel have not had the opportunity or ability to attend or contribute to assurance and learning activities. Observations can be made on behalf of an individual, crew, team, brigade, region or agency.

Consider submitting outcomes from monitoring, debriefing and reviewing activities into EM-Share or report them through the SRT (sccvic.srt@scc.vic.gov.au) to support the identification of state wide/multi-agency trends, themes and lessons.

ACCESS

EM-Share is available to personnel from community, business, industry and emergency management agencies. You can access EM-Share two ways: EM-Share button on the EM-COP Desktop; or using the link https://share.em.vic.gov.au. Chrome is the best browser to access EM-Share. If you have registered for EM-COP your login details will enable you to login to EM-Share.

Monitoring

Victoria has a Real Time Monitoring and Evaluation (RTM&E) which is a systematic and objective function that monitors operational performance of systems and processes and evaluates the effectiveness of emergency management activities. RTM&E adds value to and supports real time learning and improvement to the management of emergencies. This is achieved by providing real time feedback to participants as well as provide confidence and assurance to the EMC.
A recommendation to activate RTM&E may be made by a range of state, region and incident level personnel as per JSOP12.01 and the RTM&E Guidelines.

Debriefing

The purpose of debriefing is to identify key observations, learning opportunities and good practise to ensure learning and improvement occurs within the emergency management sector. Debriefing allows participants to, as an individual or group, walk through a series of questions enabling reflection on an experience to uncover learnings in a non-punitive environment.

DURING EVENT DEBRIEFING

Capturing aspects that are working well and those that could be improved while activated during an event reduces the requirement for post event debriefing, and enables real time learning and improvement while experiences are fresh in people's minds.

Considerations for aspects to capture during operations include:

- reasons for decisions/changes in tactics
- innovative practice
- what is working well
- areas for improvement
- ways of capturing learnings during operations may include:
- individual sheets for recording learnings before personnel finish shifts/rotations
- large sheets for personnel to collectively share learnings
- focused discussions as a collective

- promote hot debriefs at the end of shifts/rotations
- sharing EM-Share/survey tools
- activating an Assurance and Learning Officer to collect learnings and record them in EM-Share on behalf of personnel.

Also consider capturing learnings from functions, teams and organisations that provide support remotely e.g. SCC Functions.

POST EVENT DEBRIEFING

For non-major emergencies, the control agency is responsible for capturing lessons from emergencies, suggesting treatment options to the relevant accountable agencies and monitoring change/improvement actions. The scale of the debriefing should be in proportion to the complexity of the emergency.

For major emergencies, the MERC or RERC is responsible for ensuring the control agency for the emergency has undertaken this process,-including organising an operational debrief with participating agencies and teams as soon as practicable.

Representatives of all agencies who participated in the emergency operations should participate in debriefs where practicable. These agencies include response agencies, recovery agencies, partner organisations and local government. Debriefs can also include community, business, or industry groups, where relevant.

Where the debrief process identifies lessons, the control agency is responsible for identifying possible local treatments, determining appropriate actions, allocating responsibilities and monitoring progress

The control agency should communicate lessons to the EMC through the agency's SRT representative or submitted through EM-Share. The SRT collates and analyses lessons from all assurance activities to ensure continuous and consistent identification of state trends and themes.

Reviews

The purpose of reviewing is to identify key observations, learning opportunities and good practise to ensure learning and improvement occurs within the emergency management sector. A review is more structured then a debrief (or after action review), but less formal then an investigation or inquiry. It is a robust process which supports emergency management personnel to explore a specific topic and identify key learnings with the intent of instituting change.

Where an agency-led review identifies learning opportunities, the agency is responsible for identifying possible local treatments, determining appropriate actions, allocating responsibilities and monitoring progress.

Where an EMV-led review identifies learning opportunities, EMV will work with the SRT and subject matter experts to identify possible treatments, determine appropriate change/improvement actions, allocate responsibilities and monitor progress. These arrangements will be reported to the EMC, SCT and SCoT.

Assurance and Learning Unit

Agencies undertake a range of activities to provide assurance and identify learnings at incident, region and state tier before, during and after emergency incidents. When activated at the State Control Centre, the Assurance and Learning Unit facilitates the sharing of information and the coordination of resources at a state level to support local and regional assurance and learning activities, including:

- individual observation capture and analysis
- real time monitoring and evaluation deployments
- operational debriefing support
- operational reviewing support
- Before Action Report development.

PART 2 – BUSHFIRE READINESS AND RESPONSE



READINESS AND RESPONSE TO BUSHFIRE

The key to the success and safety of all personnel is the preparedness of individuals and teams. It is critical that everyone involved in responding to bushfires in Victoria – from RCs, to ICs, to Strike Team Leaders, to crew members – understand their responsibilities and take the necessary actions to prepare prior to the fire season.

Such efforts in preparedness are an essential element of the shared responsibility for bushfire safety that exists between the emergency management agencies, state and local government, communities, households and individuals. All of us are team members that rely on each other.

First response (also known as initial response or first attack) to fires and other emergencies will be fast, determined and thorough and will take precedence over normal agency activities.

Preparedness arrangements

Prior to the bushfire season, the EMC and the responder agencies prepare an integrated suite of arrangements to help them fulfil their bushfire response responsibilities.

Local Mutual Aid Plans (LMAP) identify the preparedness arrangements undertaken by the responder agencies in each region. Business Rule Local Mutual Aid Plans – Fire agencies provide the details on the content of these plans.

CFA in some areas has developed Wildfire Management Plans. These are A0 size printed documents at DCP locations as well as district offices.

Readiness arrangements

During the bushfire season the EMC, SRC and RCs, in consultation with State and Regional Agency Commanders, give direction regarding the level of resources required to be ready at particular times, to provide an effective response to bushfire.

Readiness arrangements involve establishing support for the line-of-control and could include:

- preparing and staffing the SCC
- preparing and staffing RCCs
- positioning IMTs at designated ICCs (in accordance with SOP J02.03 – Incident Management Teams – Readiness Arrangements)
- positioning incident resources to ensure an effective initial response.

Heightened levels of readiness will occur when:

- the Fire Danger Rating (FDR) in the region is severe or higher
- at the direction of the RC, in consultation with the SRC.

Both the SCC and RCC readiness arrangements will be elevated:

- when there is a Code Red FDR in one or more weather forecast districts
- when there is an Extreme FDR in three or more weather forecast districts
- at the direction of the SRC.

The responder agencies will jointly ensure resources (personnel, equipment, and facilities) are ready in accordance with the directions given by the SRC and RCs.

When establishing readiness arrangements ICs need to consider the likelihood of fires becoming a major fire and what the consequences may be.

The likelihood of a major bushfire will be increased by:

- the presence of ignition sources in the area (e.g. lightening is forecast, there is an active arsonist, or it is crop harvesting time)
- the presence of high fuel loads and low fuel moisture levels in the area
- forecasted weather conditions that indicate that unpredictable fire behaviour is likely (e.g. instability, a wind change etc. is forecast)
- existing fires in the area that could spot and cause new fires. The potential consequences from a major bushfire are increased by:

- large numbers of people in bushfire prone areas, including tourists during holiday periods and special events
- significant public infrastructure assets in the area e.g. infrastructure related to gas, electricity, telecommunications, transportation or water storages
- significant community values in the area, for example major industry or rural enterprises.

FIRE DETECTION AND DISPATCH

Early detection of and response to bushfires is vital to restricting their spread. The fire agencies detect bushfires using a range of methods including reports from the public, 'spotters' in fire towers, detection aircraft and observation by government employees during their daily activities. Fire detection arrangements are put in place to meet the forecast fire danger level.

Response arrangements

The Emergency Services Telecommunications Authority (ESTA) provides the link between the Victorian community and the state's emergency service agencies.

It provides Victoria's 24 hour emergency call taking and dispatch services – managing the provision of operational communications for the Victoria Police, CFA, FRV, Ambulance Victoria and Victoria State Emergency Service. ESTA receive Triple Zero (000) calls from the public to report fires and dispatch CFA or FRV resources.

Where a fire is detected on public land, ESTA dispatches the assigned CFA or FRV resources and contacts the Forest Fire Management Victoria (FFMVic) duty officer who may dispatch additional FFMVic resources.

FFMVic is the name for DELWP's forest and fire management program. FFMVic comprises staff from DELWP, Parks Victoria, Melbourne Water and VicForests and is tasked to reduce the risk and impact of bushfires in Victoria's parks, forests and other public land.

The responder agencies respond to the notification of bushfires according to their agency arrangements. Each bushfire has only one IC, regardless of the number of agencies responding.

In first response, the field-based IC communicates to their agency through their agency command arrangements. In addition to normal agency communications, the information communicated should include:

- the effectiveness of the incident control arrangements
- potential risks or consequences
- the need for specialist resources, including people or equipment.

The EMC, SRCr and RC maintain an overview of the emergency situation, through contact with Agency Commanders. Their level of involvement in the management of an incident relates to the likelihood of it becoming a major emergency.

COMMAND

The agencies retain command of their own resources and maintain their chain-of-command.

For bushfire management, the command structure of each responder agency aligns with the state tiers of emergency management as follows:

- the Chief Officer is usually the State Agency Commander
- operational personnel under the command of a Chief Officer include personnel employed by the agency, engaged as volunteers or engaged partnership arrangements
- each Chief Officer appoints Regional Agency Commanders at the regional tier, where the agency holds jurisdiction.

During the bushfire season, Agency Commanders from the responder agencies are responsible for monitoring the activities of the resources within their command, ensuring they are supporting the line-of-control.

Functional areas

CONTROL

To assist the IMT and IEMT achieve the state emergency management priorities, the IC should be mindful of the following activities:

- dynamic risk assessment
- continuous situational awareness
- issuing information and warnings
- incident intelligence
- incident prediction
- weather prognosis
- mapping
- resources
- incident management structure – division (field) command, incident, regional and state control
- understanding community impact and consequences – discuss with IEMT
- communications – maintain two-way communications with IMT, IEMT and regional/state control.

Traffic management points

In addition to the TMP access levels the following stickers are provided to those wishing to gain access to the fire area.

Emergency response personnel TMP access

All FFMVic vehicles with government (red) plates need staff suitability attired in PPE (i.e. green overalls and helmets) and displaying either the 'Fire and Emergency Management' adhesive label on the windscreen or FFMVic external vehicle markings. FFMVic vehicles without red plates (e.g. vehicles or prime movers hired over the summer, and Melbourne Water/VicForests vehicles) will need 'Private Firefighting Equipment' stickers (see figure 7).

FIGURE 7: TRAFFIC MANAGEMENT POINT VEHICLE STICKER



Media TMP access

Media representatives are permitted access at a TMP designated as Authorised Access – C. Such access will be subject to authorisation by, and in accordance with conditions set, by the IC.

The IC may authorise access for media personnel through a TMP at access level Emergency Service Only access or Restricted Access – B, under escort by emergency response agency personnel and any other conditions, where they deem it safe and appropriate. Such arrangement and the conditions of such access will be communicated to the TMP prior to the arrival of the media.

In all cases where media representatives are permitted access, they are required to be in possession of a CFA/FFMVic accreditation and authorised PPE.

Media passes expire after three years (see figure 8) after which individuals are required to undertake further training. The expiry date on the pass will need to be checked by TMP personnel before granting entry.

FIGURE 8: MEDIA PASS



OPERATIONS

Bushfire status

CFA and FFMVic use common terms to define the status of a bushfire, however FFMVic subdivide the statuses Controlled and Safe (see table 6 below).

TABLE 6: INCIDENT STATUS – FFMVIC

INCIDENT STATUS	DEFINITION	FFMVIC SUBDIVISION	DEFINITION
GOING	Fire expanding in a certain direction or directions.		
CONTAINED	The spread of the fire is halted.		
CONTROLLED	The complete perimeter of a fire is secured and no breakaway is expected.	Under Control 1	The complete perimeter of the fire is secured, no breakaway is expected.
		Under Control 2	The complete perimeter of the fire is secured, and no breakaway is expected. Control line quality or depth is such that only patrol is required.
SAFE	No further suppression action or patrols are necessary.	Safe	No further suppression action or patrols are necessary.
		Safe – False alarm	Mistaken or hoax report
		Safe – Not found	The fire has not been located, and it is expected that no further action or patrol will be required.
		Safe – Overun	The fire has been overrun by another fire.

The fire agencies also have a range of incident status terminology for use in a Computer Aided Dispatch (CAD) environment (see table 7). These wordbacks reflect incident status and are also linked to resource requirements.

TABLE 7: CFA AND FRV

INCIDENT STATUS	DEFINITION
NOT YET UNDER CONTROL (CFA)\ ALARM LEVEL (FRV)	The fire or incident has the potential to spread or increase in difficulty. The appliances and personnel in attendance may not be sufficient.
UNDER CONTROL (CFA & FRV)	The resources in attendance and en route are sufficient to contain the incident.
STOP (CFA & FRV)	The resources presently in attendance at the incident are sufficient. Resources that are en route are not required and may return to their own locations.

Bushfire classification

Bushfires are classified in a range from Level 1 to Level 3.

Level 1

A small, simple fire (or group fires) which is controlled with local resources (may include other agencies) with the IC probably undertaking more than one function.

Example – A fire where a second shift unlikely to be required and may be approximately 0–5ha with no complex problems.

Level 2

A fire that cannot be contained by the first attack of local resources and becomes more complex. A Level 2 incident is characterised by the need for:

- the deployment of resources beyond initial response
- sectorisation of the incident
- the establishment of functional sections due to the levels of complexity
- a combination of the above.

Example – A fire where it is expected that is will be controlled within 24 hours. Approximately 5–20ha (or much larger if the complexity is low), or with some complexity and control problems.

Level 3

A large or complex fire where resources from a range of locations are involved. Generally, it will involve multiple agencies and will normally be expected to exceed 24 hours.

Level 3 incidents are characterised by degrees of complexity that may require the establishment of Divisions for effective management of the situation. These incidents will usually involve delegation of all functions.

These fires are major emergencies.

Aircraft and aviation – Predetermined Dispatch

Predetermined Dispatch (PDD) is a system which authorises the dispatch of aircraft by pager, often concurrently with ground resources when specific criteria (time of day and FDI) are met. Aircraft dispatched via the PDD system operate from various regional locations.

This will sometimes result in aircraft operating at fires prior to, or very soon after, the arrival of ground resources.

All aircraft can still be dispatched by the SAD and all aircraft (including those dispatched by PDD) are required be re-tasked through the SAD.

It is important that communications are established and maintained between the aircraft and ground resources at all times to ensure both the safety of aircraft and ground resources, together with the effective tasking of aircraft.

In some instances, aircraft may undertake initial attack without an Air Attack Supervisor (AAS). IAOP SO 4.07 – Firebombing Operations outlines when this can occur and the ICs responsibilities.

The combined effort of ground resources and aircraft improves the effectiveness of response operations. It is vital that strategies and tactics are consistent and understood by aircraft and ground commanders.

RCs manage the requirements of SOP J02.06 Readiness Arrangements – Aviation Resources. To support this, the FireWeb Aviation readiness tab is required to be populated and updated with current information.

PLANNING

Incident communications planning

Agencies need to ensure that Joint Default Communications Plans are prepared to cover their respective districts before each fire season. Refer to SOP J02.02 – Incident Communications Planning.

Joint Default Communications Plans are documented in all relevant Local Mutual Aid Plans in accordance with Joint Business Rule – Local Mutual Aid Plans – Fire agencies.

Joint Default Communications Plans are required to be implemented at each multi-agency incident, until the IC replaces it with a specific Incident Communications Plan, if required.

Aboriginal cultural heritage planning

Specific risks associated with impacts to Aboriginal cultural heritage can occur in the planning and preparation phase for bushfires.

The greatest risk to Aboriginal cultural heritage at this time is the construction of fire breaks, control lines and other logistical infrastructure that requires earthmoving machinery. Risks include harming surface or sub-surface artefact scatters, freshwater or coastal middens and mounds.

In addition, fire suppression actives, such as dropping chemical fire retardants could harm rock art. The greatest risks during a bushfire is scarred trees being burned and either destroyed outright or made hazardous due to significant burning. The greatest risks in the recovery phase are the felling of scarred trees that have been marked as hazardous, but not identified as Aboriginal cultural heritage.

There are also the same risks to Aboriginal cultural heritage being impacted by earthmoving equipment as in the planning and preparation phase. A lack of due diligence when reinstating or relocating assets and rehabilitating land is also a risk to both known and unknown cultural values.

Seeking input from an Aboriginal Cultural Heritage Values Advisor early in the process and deploying one into an IMT will aid in minimising the chances of accidental impacts to Aboriginal cultural heritage and assisting with assessments during all phases on the incident management process.

LOGISTICS

Catering

Red Cross provide food and water emergency relief to affected communities, including at relief centres, but no longer provide these services to the emergency service agencies.

The Municipal Emergency Management Plans (MEMPs), LMAPs and any other relevant agency plans should have details of local arrangements for catering.

Base camps

The State owns infrastructure for three base camps, each with a capacity to support 200–500 personnel. A base camp usually provides services such as catering facilities, hygiene facilities, first aid, laundry, accommodation facilities, a car park, maintenance and service facilities, PPE/PPC, small equipment replacement supply, water supply and other services (e.g. telephone access, information boards).

Base camp components can be deployed individually or as a 'set' including:

- kitchen and kitchen support
- laundry
- supply cache
- base camp support
- camping set for 75
- camping set for 100
- showers
- toilets.

For example, kitchen and kitchen support containers can be set up at a staging area to provide catering for longer incidents.

Requests for base camps are approved through the line of control. Further information is available on the IMT toolbox (FFMVic staff can also access this information through the Altona Warehouse Management System (AWMS)).

When considering the establishment of a base camp, ensure that:

- Appropriately trained logistics personnel are available to plan and implement.
- Planning is undertaken incorporating the size, scalability, costs, duration, location and adequate resourcing for set up, maintenance and demobilisation.
- Consideration on whether a base camp is the best option; a base camp is a resource intensive and expensive service.

Mobilisation for a small camp (under 200 pax) can occur within approximately 24–72 hours of a request, with meals available after 24 hours (depending on the incident location proximity to Melbourne).

Demobilisation for a small camp (under 200 pax) takes 3–5 days contingent upon dry weather. The Logistics section in the IMT is required to continue to function under the direction of the IC until demobilisation is complete.

INTELLIGENCE

Fire Behaviour Analysts

Fire Behaviour Analysts (FBANs) analyse factors including fuels, fire history, weather and topography to forecast likely fire behaviour. They may do this manually and/or using computer simulation models. FBANs use a combination of forecast and field verified data in their predictions. It is important that FBANs are notified when more detailed information is obtained (e.g. fire location) or if on-ground conditions differ significantly from the predicted

FBANs can assist in decision-making before, during and after an incident. They can provide a variety of services including:

- Identification of areas and times of greatest risk.
- Fire behaviour prediction maps, showing likely fire progression and potential impact zones.
- Advice on incident objectives, strategies and tactics.
- Information on the factors impacting on spread and behaviour of a grass or bushfire.
- Assessment of the fire behaviour potential of going, contained and controlled fires. It is critical that FBAN intelligence is shared with IMT members and the field personnel through IAPs and briefings to support safe effective operations. Critical FBAN intelligence can be conveyed via a Field Information Update or Red Flag Warning as appropriate.

Incident weather forecasts

An Incident Weather Forecast is provided by the Bureau of Meteorology for a specific location, focusing on weather parameters that affect fire behaviour. It typically covers 24 hours and includes a table of forecast temperature, dew point, relative humidity, wind direction, windspeed, windgust, upper winds, Forest Fire Danger Index (FFDI), Grass Fire Danger Index (GFDI), cHaines Index, mixing height and Thunderstorm Activity Level at hourly intervals for the first 12 hours, then 3 hourly out to 24 hours. The tabular weather parameters are prefaced by written commentary that address forecast certainty associated with significant wind changes, thunderstorm potential, precipitation and cloud as well as spatial variations within the vicinity of the forecast site (particularly important mountainous terrain).

Only when other readily available forecast information does not supply the necessary detail, consider requesting an incident weather forecast, this may include the use of BoM MetEye service.

Incident Weather Forecasts have a very high priority in the BoM Victoria forecast office, second only to the preparation and distribution of Wind Change Forecast Maps. This means forecasters will stop work on other products to prepare an Incident Weather Forecast. Requests should only be submitted for going fires, not those considered contained or controlled, unless previously agreed. The complexity of the terrain surrounding the request site affects the preparation time, as numerous local weather effects may need to be considered. Typical turnaround times range from 20 to 45 minutes. If numerous requests are received in a short period, turnaround times may be longer.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

Fire danger ratings

Fire Danger Ratings are communicated to the public to inform them about the fire risk on any given day and the associated suggested actions (see figure 9).

FIGURE 9: FIRE DANGER INDICES

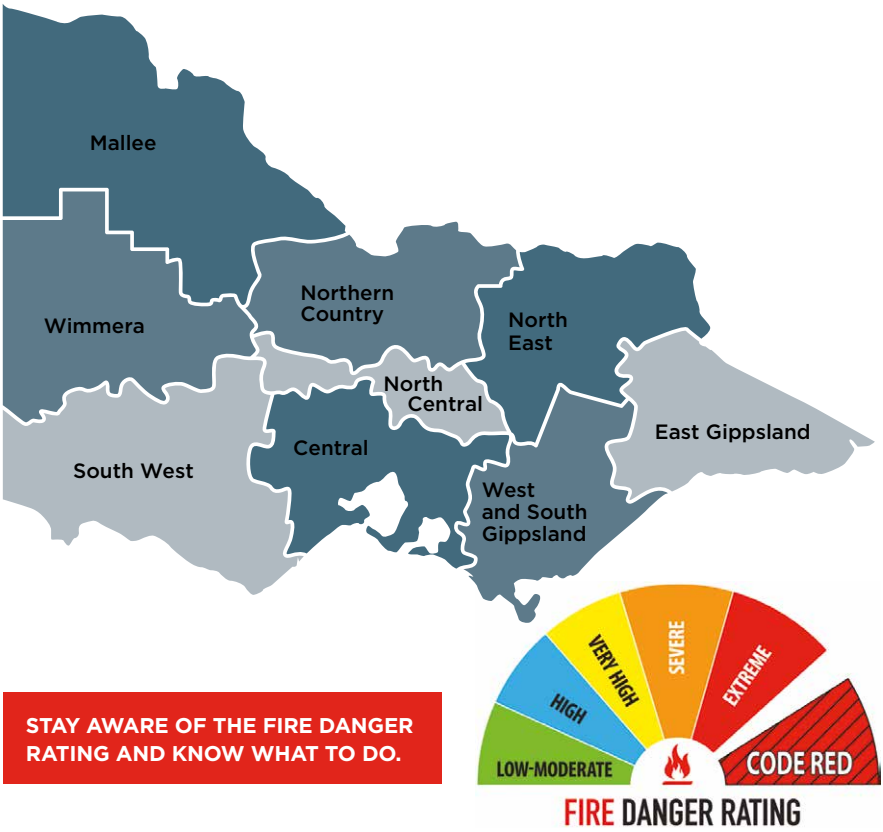
FIRE DANGER RATING	GRASSLAND FIRE DANGER INDEX	FOREST FIRE DANGER INDEX
CODE RED	150+	100+
EXTREME	100–149	75–99
SEVERE	50–99	50–74
VERY HIGH	25–49	25–49
HIGH	12–24	12–24
LOW-MODERATE	0–11	0–11

Fire Dangers Ratings for the Wimmera, Mallee and Northern Country weather districts (see figure 10) are forecast using the grassland Fire Danger Index triggers. Fire Danger Ratings for the remaining weather districts are forecast using the forest Fire Danger Index triggers. The community is presented with one Fire Danger Rating for each district.

The Fire Danger Rating predicts how difficult it would be to put out the fire.

The higher the rating, the more dangerous the conditions. The rating is your trigger to act, so to stay safe you need to stay aware of the Fire Danger Rating in your district.

FIGURE 10: WEATHER FORECAST AND TOTAL FIRE BAN DISTRICTS



During the fire season, the Fire Danger Rating will feature in weather forecasts, be broadcast on radio and TV, and appear in some newspapers.

It can also be found on the websites of CFA, DEWLP and Bureau of Meteorology, by calling the VicEmergency Hotline on 1800 226 226 or via National Relay Service on 1800 555 677.

FIGURE 11: FIRE DANGER RATING DESCRIPTORS

FIRE DANGER RATING	WHAT DOES IT MEAN?	WHAT SHOULD I DO?
CODE RED	These are the worst conditions for a bush or grass fire. Homes are not designed or constructed to withstand fires in these conditions. The safest place to be is away from high-risk bushfire areas.	Leaving high-risk bushfire areas the night before or early in the day is your safest option – do not wait and see. Avoid forested areas, thick bush or long, dry grass. Know your trigger – make a decision about: • when you will leave • where you will go • how you will get there • when you will return • what you will do if you cannot leave.
EXTREME	Expect extremely hot, dry and windy conditions. If a fire starts and takes hold, it will be uncontrollable, unpredictable and fast moving. Spot fires will start, move quickly and come from many directions. Homes that are situated and constructed or modified to withstand a bushfire, that are well prepared and actively defended, may provide safety. You must be physically and mentally prepared to defend in these conditions.	• Consider staying with your property only if you are prepared to the highest level. This means your home needs to be situated and constructed or modified to withstand a bushfire, you are well prepared and you can actively defend your home if a fire starts. • If you are not prepared to the highest level, leaving high-risk bushfire areas early in the day is your safest option. • Be aware of local conditions and seek information by listening to ABC Local Radio, commercial and designated community radio stations or watch Sky News TV, visit cfa.vic.gov.au, call the VicEmergency Hotline on 1800 226 226 or via the National Relay Service on 1800 555 677.

FIRE DANGER RATING	WHAT DOES IT MEAN?	WHAT SHOULD I DO?
SEVERE	Expect hot, dry and possibly windy conditions. If a fire starts and takes hold, it may be uncontrollable. Well prepared homes that are actively defended can provide safety. You must be physically and mentally prepared to defend in these conditions.	• Well prepared homes that are actively defended can provide safety – check your Bushfire Survival Plan. • If you are not prepared, leaving bushfire-prone areas early in the day is your safest option. • Be aware of local conditions. Seek information by listening to ABC Local Radio, commercial and designated community radio stations or watch Sky News TV, visit cfa.vic.gov.au, call the VicEmergency Hotline on 1800 226 226 or via the National Relay Service on 1800 555 677.
VERY HIGH HIGH LOW-MODERATE	If a fire starts, it can most likely be controlled in these conditions.	• Check your Bushfire Survival Plan • Monitor conditions • Action may be needed • Leave if necessary.

Community fire refuges

A community fire is a designated public building that may provide short-term shelter from the immediate life-threatening effects of a bushfire.

Victoria has five official community fire refuges:

- East Warburton
- Ferny Creek
- Lavers Hill
- Millgrove
- Blackwood

Media attendance at incidents – protocols

Working with the media

Fire agencies work in partnership with media agencies and media representatives during emergencies. Media have a critical role, communicating critical community safety messages and newsworthy information, stories, interviews and images. Media is one of the most commonly used sources of information about emergencies by the community.

The control agency, through the IC, is responsible for ensuring they provide and maintain, so far as is reasonably practicable, a work environment that is safe and without risks of impacting the safety of all incident personnel, including firefighters and media representatives.

Accreditation and identification of media

To work with fire agencies at bushfires, all media representatives are required to have:

- a current media accreditation card (obtained on completing CFA safety training)
- fire agency approved PPE, including CFA approved 'MEDIA' patches on the upper back, front left pocket and right sleeve of the equipment, all to be worn as directed during the time the media are on the fireground.

The IC may grant permission to attend the incident, particularly the fire ground, only if it has been deemed safe and practicable to do so, and if the media representatives have achieved all the minimum requirements for working with fire agencies at bushfires.

Upon deeming it safe and appropriate for media representatives to attend the incident, the control agency will articulate the specific conditions for that attendance on each occasion and refer the media representative to the Public Information Officer or Media Officer.

The Media Officer will ensure that media representatives receive a safety briefing prior to entering the fire ground and that appropriate communication arrangements are in place.

Victoria Police Officers may remove media representatives from the fire ground who are endangering their own lives or the lives of others.

While on the fire ground, media representatives are required to comply with any instruction provided to them by the Media Officer, PIO, IC or Victoria Police. This includes immediate departure from the fire ground, should this be deemed a necessary safety measure.

Non-compliance

Media accreditation may be withdrawn, and media representatives may be escorted from the fire ground and not permitted to return in instances where a media representative:

- Has endangered their own safety, or the safety of others.
- Failed to comply with instructions of the Media Officer, PIO, Incident Controller or any representative of the fire agencies or Victoria Police while n the fire ground.
- Failed to depart immediately from the fire ground after instruction by the Media Officer, or any representative of the responder agencies, or Victoria Police.
- Accessed any area beyond TMP without the permission of the IC or an escort by CFA or FFMVic staff.

The agencies may formally advise WorkSafe of the incident if appropriate. The SCC Public Information Section can contact the relevant media agency to advise them that their media representative has failed to comply.

SAFETY

WATCHOUT

WATCHOUT is an acronym used to remind firefighters of potential dangers to their safety and to give advice on safe work practices. Understanding the meaning of the acronym will help you perform a more comprehensive risk assessment.

W	**EATHER** dominates fire behaviour, so keep informed
A	**CTIONS** need to be based on current and expected fire behaviour
T	**RY OUT** at least two safe escape routes
C	**OMMUNICATE** with your supervisor, your crew and adjoining crews
H	**AZARDS** beware of variations in fuels and steep slopes
O	**BSERVE** changes in wind speed, direction, temperature, humidity and cloud
U	**NDERSTAND** your instructions, make sure that you are understood
T	**HINK** clearly, be alert and act decisively before your situation becomes critical

You should familiarise yourself with your agency's current WATCHOUTs. Firefighter's watchout when:

- building a control line downhill towards a fire
- on a slope – rolling material can ignite fuel below you
- the wind changes speed or direction
- the weather gets hotter or drier
- there are unburnt fuels between you and the fire
- terrain or vegetation impedes travel or visibility
- working in country areas you have not seen in daylight
- you are unfamiliar with the weather and local fire behaviour
- frequent spot fires occur over your control line
- you cannot see the main fire or communicate with anyone who can
- unclear instructions or tasks are given
- you feel exhausted or want to take a nap near the fire
- attacking a fire or constructing a fire control line without a safe anchor point
- working alone with no communications link to crew members or supervisor
- you are not fully informed about strategy, tactics and hazards
- safety zones and escape routes have not been identified
- fire not scouted or the potential of the fire has not been assessed
- water levels are getting low.

Smoke

Significant smoke or emissions from fires or hazardous materials incidents need consideration in terms of protecting both workforce and community from harmful effects. Smoke is harmful and early in any incident the composition will be unknown, so basic protective actions i.e. avoid exposure, minimise exposure, personal protective respiratory protection should be considered.

If the density of smoke or emissions is predicted to last a considerable time and potentially impact workers or the community, consideration must be given to:

- The provision of advice to protect both workers and the community.
- Deployment of monitoring equipment to the incident site to monitor composition and exposure of workforce.
- If smoke or emissions are significant, potentially deploy monitoring within the community that is impacted by smoke or emissions.

Early consideration for the need for monitoring of significant events, along with early activation will help inform decision making by ICs. Fire agencies and the Environment Protection Authority, have a range of monitoring tools available for agencies to deploy, as required.

The following documents contain more information on smoke:

- State Smoke Framework.
- SOP J031.8 Incident Air Quality Monitoring.
- SOP J031.9 Managing Significant Community Exposures to Fine Particles and Carbon Monoxide in smoke from fires.

Tree hazard

Tree hazard is a major risk to firefighters and responders at all stages of operations, from active suppression, mopping up and patrol through to recovery. The key steps to protect responders from tree hazard are:

Step 1 Identify the potential existence of tree hazard during bushfire response.

Step 2 Mitigate the risk arising from tree hazard during access to bushfire incidents.

Step 3 Mitigate the risk arising from tree hazard on the fire ground.

Step 4 Mitigate the risk of unidentified hazard trees on the fire ground.

Step 5 Complete operations.

For further information on Tree Hazards see SOP J08.03 Tree Hazard – Bushfire Response.

Initial attack and tree hazard

Awareness and identification of trees which present a hazard need to form part of the ongoing dynamic risk assessment performed by all personnel on the fire ground at all times. During an attack on a going fire, personnel need to be particularly vigilant in identifying hazard trees and treating any unacceptable risks.

Following the passage of the fire

Hazard trees within striking distance of access/control lines are assessed, marked and treated as soon as possible after the passage of fire, and before the commencement of any mop-up/blacking out/patrol. Prescribed qualified or experienced personnel can carry out tree hazard assessments.

Marking system

Yellow dot '•' is sprayed on non-hazard trees to be protected (i.e. hand raked or machine cleared around and/or fire suppressant applied) prior to the fire or back burn.

Yellow cross 'X' is sprayed on hazardous trees (not yet Clear and Present Danger), or potential Clear and Present Danger trees which cannot be reliably protected. These trees will normally be pushed over or felled as part of access/control line construction.

FIGURE 12: TREE HAZARD IDENTIFICATION

FIRST ATTACK GUIDE – SYSTEM OF WORK

K

INITIAL ATTACK

Clear & Present Danger (CPD) trees, also known as Killer (K) trees must be identified continuously using Dynamic Risk Assessment (DRA).

Consider moving the control line to an area with reduced numbers of hazardous trees.

IDENTIFY then **EXCLUDE** or **REMOVE** and **COMMUNICATE**

All crews can and should identify K trees as part of DRA

THE K SYMBOL

Marked on two sides of tree if safe to do so

K 30cm K symbol only

Clearly visible from control line

1.5m off the ground or at visible height



K TREES

- Identify on foot
- Crews must be isolated from the hazard by establishing an exclusion zone or other method (eg. road closure)
- If falling the tree, the use of appropriate machinery is the preferred and safest method
- Accredited fallers are the next safest option (advanced or intermediate)

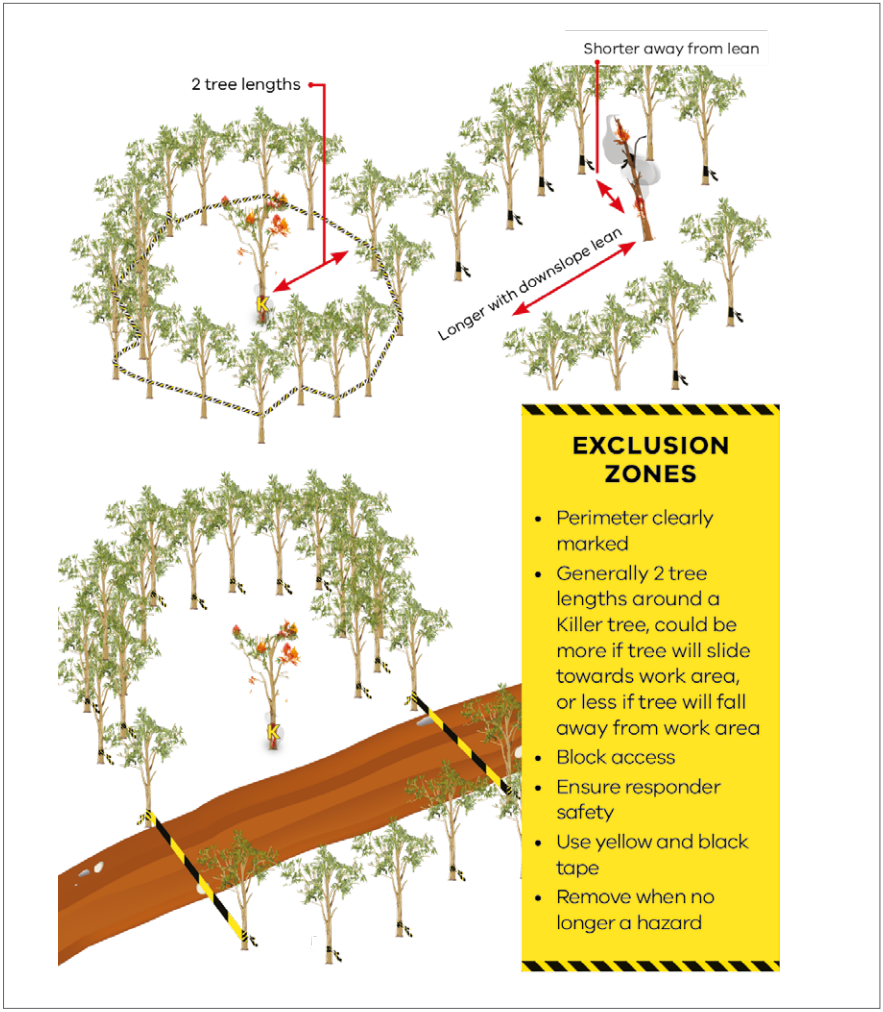
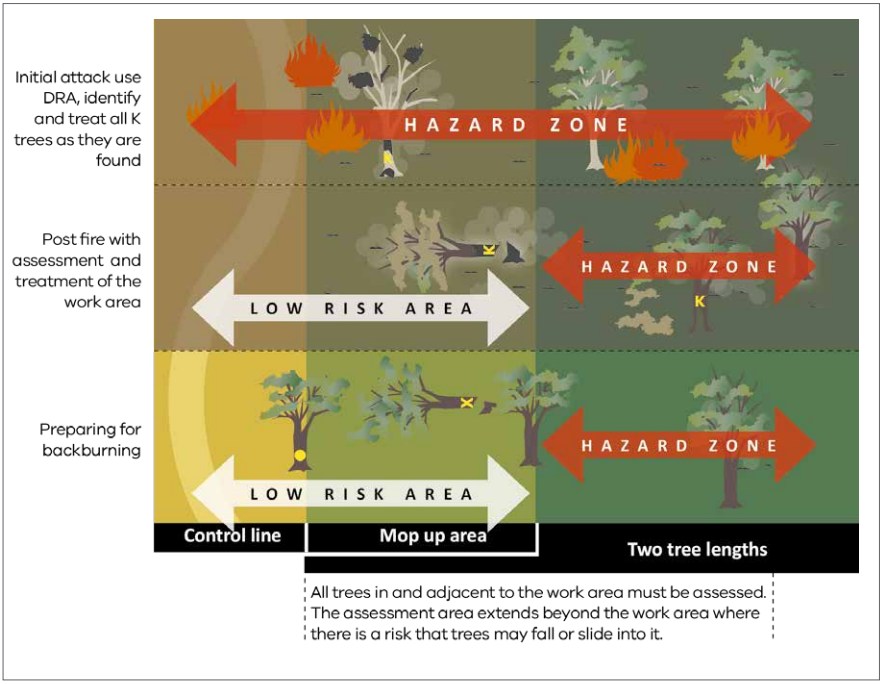

Shorter away from lean
2 tree lengths
Longer with downslope lean
K
K
EXCLUSION ZONES
• Perimeter clearly marked
• Generally 2 tree lengths around a Killer tree, could be more if tree will slide towards work area, or less if tree will fall away from work area
• Block access
• Ensure responder safety
• Use yellow and black tape
• Remove when no longer a hazard

FIGURE 12: TREE HAZARD IDENTIFICATION (CONTINUED)



Yellow ‘K’ is sprayed on trees that present a ‘Clear and Present Danger’ which are likely to fall on personnel while working in the area.

All responders can identify Clear and Present Danger (CPD) Trees (‘K’) through a DRA. As a minimum, an exclusion zone should be established and the location of an identified Clear and Present Danger Tree (‘K’) reported. ‘K’ should only be spray painted when they are assessed as being safe enough to approach by a qualified or experienced person.

Exclusion zones

An exclusion zone is marked with yellow and black tape tied around a tree or trees at the perimeter of the exclusion zone on the approach to a ‘K’ tree. No one should enter the exclusion zone unless they are tasked to assess or treat the risk. Personnel wanting to access the area are required to either wait until the hazard has been safely treated or find other means of access outside the exclusion zone. In exceptional circumstances (e.g. where life is under threat) DRA should be applied.

The exclusion zone is generally two tree lengths; however, it may be larger, or in some cases smaller depending on site conditions such as topography and tree lean.

If it is unsafe or not possible to fall or push over a ‘K’ tree then other options include retaining the exclusion zone, moving, re-aligning or abandoning the control line where the risk poses cannot be treated.

Post incident

FIRE INVESTIGATION

In the event of a fire being suspicious, the IC is to ensure the scene is preserved and request Victoria Police and a Fire Investigator to attend scene. The IC should provide Victoria Police the details of why the fire is deemed suspicious.

Joint Business Rule – Bushfire investigation, describes the procedures for bushfire investigation.

REHABILITATION

Rehabilitation initially involves emergency stabilisation activities which are considered necessary for the restoration or re-establishment of infrastructure, other assets and environmental values affected by the impact of bushfire and suppression activities and to prevent further degradation from these impacts.

Emergency stabilisation and rehabilitation should be initiated by the IC as soon as possible after firefighting operations commence, but without compromising control of the fire. Emergency stabilisation should be carried out prior to suppression machinery leaving the fire ground.

Emergency stabilisation works include:

- Emergency erosion control to protect life and property post fire.
- Works to protect road network from increased risk of flooding or erosion.
- Removal of hazardous trees along the road network or at recreation sites.
- Opening or closing roads post fire for public safety.
- Rehabilitation of fire control lines on public or private land.
- Repair or replacement of fences damaged directly by the fire agencies during the course of suppression.
- Essential water replacement.
- Deployment of Bushfire Rapid Risk Assessment Teams to initiate recovery plans. Rehabilitation will often continue post incident as part of the transition to longer term recovery.

PART 3 – FLOOD AND STORM



FLOOD AND STORM

Authorising environment

In addition to the common emergency management and agency specific acts, there are a number of other Acts and Regulations that impose restriction on control and support agencies when working in flood and storm events.

The functions of VICSES as described in the *Victoria State Emergency Service Act 2005* (Vic) are to respond to floods and storms and their effects; and providing rescue services.

The Water Act 1989 (Vic) lists the floodplain management functions of Catchment Management Authorities and Melbourne Water. These functions include the determination of the extent and depth of floodwater; the development and implementation of plans; take any action necessary to minimise flooding and flood damage; and to provide advice about flooding and controls. Additional requirements relate to controlling works and structures on floodplains, although enforced through planning controls in planning schemes.

The Meteorology Act 1955 (Cth) contains the functions of the Bureau of Meteorology (BoM) including the issue of warnings of gales, storms and other weather conditions likely to endanger life or property, including weather conditions likely to give rise to floods or bushfires.

Emergency risk management

Emergency management involves managing the risk of emergency events on the community and its values. In order to manage risk, we need to understand the hazard and its impacts.

In the context of this document, extreme weather and storm events includes phenomena associated with severe weather systems and severe thunderstorms such as:

- damaging and destructive winds
- heavy rainfall that may lead to flash flooding
- large hail
- tornados
- blizzards
- storm surge.

Flooding is generally categorised into two types; riverine and flash.

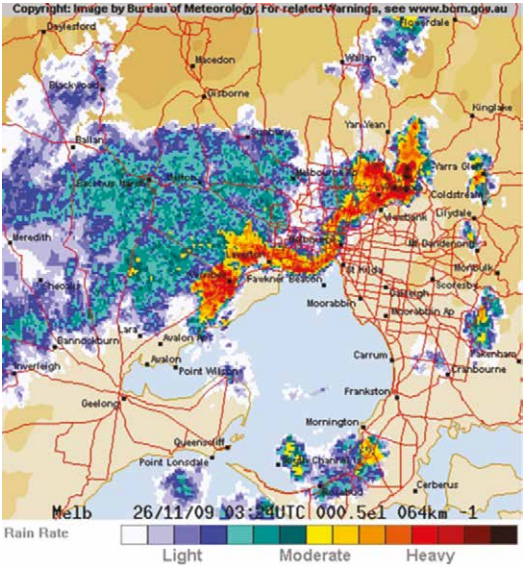
Extreme weather climatology

The most frequent type of extreme weather events are thunderstorms. Although severe thunderstorms can occur at any time, the potential is higher during September through to April.

Wind storms (land gale-force winds) associated with the passage of a cold front or intense low-pressure systems across Victoria can occur at any time of year although are more common in the winter and spring months when intense low pressure systems and cold fronts are stronger.

On a seasonal basis, rainfall over the central and southwestern areas of Victoria is at a maximum in late winter and early spring. Flooding in Victoria is largely influenced by rainfall distribution and rainfall intensity and is commonly a winter-spring phenomenon in Victoria, associated with frequent low-pressure systems and fronts. Some major flood events have occurred in the summer period, commonly associated with weather systems of tropical origin extending or moving south.

FIGURE 13: STORM RADAR IMAGE



Blizzards are confined to alpine areas in Victoria and mainly occur during the winter and early spring months but can also occur in autumn. It does not have to be snowing to have blizzard conditions and the winds should be at least gale force (average 63km/h or more).

River systems

The river systems in Victoria are divided into 29 catchments, with the Murray River falling under the jurisdiction of New South Wales government to the low water mark on the Victorian bank.

FIGURE 14: VICTORIAN RIVER CATCHMENTS



Floodplain management

DELWP is responsible for policy and oversight of floodplain risk management arrangements.

Floodplain Risk Management Planning is a subset of the community emergency risk management process focused on identifying and analysing flood risks; and evaluating and recommending appropriate flood risk treatment options. This is best achieved through a flood study, floodplain risk management study and a floodplain risk management plan to identify the flood risks and how these might be best managed. The State Floodplain Management Strategy – sets out the policy framework for managing floodplains in Victoria.

Prevention activities cover both structural and non-structural measures. Structural measures have traditionally included flood mitigation works, such as levees, retarding basins, channel modifications and the structural or floor level modifications to buildings. Non-structural measures include land use planning, building controls, and community risk awareness programs.

Catchment Management Authorities (CMAs) and Melbourne Water have statutory functions under the Water Act 1989 to manage waterways, floodplains and drainage.

Local government has a significant role to play in the administration of land use planning arrangements and flood mitigation at the local level.

Flood emergency management

Flood emergencies by their nature require a multi-agency response. Part 7 of the EMMV, identifies VICSES as the control agency for Flood Response.

Flood emergency management brings together Whole-of-Victorian-Government resources and the community to take appropriate and timely action in relation to flood preparedness, response, relief and recovery.

Total Flood Warning System (TFWS)

The goal of flood warning is to help flood management agencies and the members of flood-prone communities to understand the nature of developing floods so that they can take action to mitigate their effects. To achieve this goal, flood warning systems are established and operated across the state.

A flood warning system is made up of a number of components which need be integrated if the system is to operate effectively. The components of the TFWS are:

- monitoring of rainfall and river flows that may lead to flooding
- prediction of flood severity and the time of onset of particular levels of flooding
- interpretation of the prediction to determine the likely flood impacts on the community
- construction of warning messages describing what is happening and will happen, the expected impact and what actions should be taken
- dissemination of warning messages
- response to the warnings by the agencies.

Levee management

There are many levee systems within Victoria and the design, operation and maintenance arrangements vary widely across the state. Some levees are formally maintained, but many are not, therefore, unless documented in emergency response plans, no reliance should be placed on levees that are not maintained. Where maintained, levee managers are required keep the control agency informed of the levee status and be prepared to provide expert advice about the design and construction of their levee, and any concerns over its performance.

During an incident the Victoria State Emergency Service Act 2005 provides for personnel authorised by VICSES the power to construct, remove, or alter a levee and/or remove debris where there is a reasonable belief that removal is required to protect life or property.

Dam management

DELWP has a regulatory role in the safety of dams in Victoria. This includes dams categorised as farm dams, private dams and dams operated by water corporations, Parks Victoria and local government.

Dam owners and operators are responsible for the maintenance, operation and management of the dam.

Generally, large dams in Victoria are not designed or operated specifically for flood mitigation, although some flood mitigation is provided as a result of the flow being attenuated by the dam.

Only a small number of dams have spillway gates, providing the capability to make flow releases prior to or during flooding.

Community resilience

UNDERSTANDING COMMUNITY RISK

Catchment Management Authorities regularly undertake flood studies across the state to assist in the planning and prevention of flooding on communities. The outcomes of these studies inform flood protection and planning schemes.

To assist the community in understanding their risk and to support informed decision making, VICSES has developed a number of flood guides and emergency plans to explain local flood risks for at risk communities and provide advice on how to prepare for and respond to flood events.

LOCAL KNOWLEDGE

There are a range of information sources available to emergency services before, during and after incidents. Information sources many include local knowledge obtained from trusted sources such as community members and organisations. Local knowledge information can provide valuable local information about incidents on how they have or may evolve.

Community observer networks have been established by VICSES in areas where existing networks are not available, and the need for local knowledge has been identified. VICSES also works with other organisations and agencies to access local knowledge through existing networks. Where these network arrangements exist, they are documented within Municipal Flood Emergency Plans.

Readiness and response

CAPACITY

In order to respond to flood and storm events the agencies have established a number of mechanisms to enhance the state's capacity.

These include:

- Contractual arrangements in order to access personnel from the private sector providing expertise, in flood hydrology, mapping and engineering, to support intelligence and operational decision making.
- Memorandums of Understanding have been established with NSW and SA to ensure that operational activity across the borders is managed in a unified and consistent manner.
- Use of local knowledge through the community observer networks established through VICSES and other local networks such as local government, CMAs, other agencies and community groups.
- Investment in the development of a flood intelligence platform and monitoring systems, assist in the gathering and collating data.

STATE PLANNING, READINESS AND ACTIVATION

The State Flood sub-plan and State Storm Sub-plan provides sources of information and to outline the arrangements for ensuring an integrated and coordinated approach to the State's management of flood and storm events, in order to reduce the impact and consequences of these events on the community, infrastructure and services.

A copy of the State Flood and State Storm sub-plan is available via the EM-COP website.

Readiness and activation

Readiness arrangements for the State are scalable, adaptable, and based on risk. On a monthly basis BoM provide DELWP and VICSES risk assessment briefings on the rainfall outlook and flood potential. The outcomes from these briefings inform the readiness planning undertaken by these agencies.

State Readiness and Activation is to be in line with SOP J02.03 Incident Management Team (IMT) Readiness Arrangements and VICSES Readiness and Activation Triggers.

The State tier is to have documented plans and processes for the activation of State Resources and Facilities in the occurrence of a no notice event. Each State Duty Officer and State Agency Commander is to be aware of these plans, with the processes regularly exercised.

REGIONAL READINESS, ACTIVATION AND PLANNING

Planning

Each Emergency Management Region has a documented Flood sub-plan and Storm sub-plan to outline the response arrangements to flood and storm incidents within that Region's area of responsibility.

A copy of each Regions plan is available via EM-COP or the VICSES website.

Readiness and activation

Regional Readiness and Activation is to be in line with SOP J02.03 Incident Management Team (IMT) Readiness Arrangements and VICSES Readiness and Activation Triggers.

Actions that may be undertaken by the Regional Agency Commander and Regional Duty Officer include:

- Briefings to Units on the forecast event.
- Prepositioning of specialist teams such as USAR or LBSWR.
- Relocation of state/regional/unit assets.
- Identification of members to undertake IMT roles at Incident Control Centres.
- Briefings to State on readiness and response actions.

Each Region is to have documented plans and processes for the activation of Regional Resources and Facilities in the occurrence of a no notice event. Each Regional Duty Officer and Regional Agency Commander is to be aware of these plans, with the processes regularly exercised within the Region.

UNIT READINESS, ACTIVATION AND PLANNING

For day to day VICSES Operations, Unit Duty Officers and Unit Management Teams need to be aware of the current resources available to their individual unit. If a Unit believes that they do not have sufficient resources available for response, they are to escalate this to the Regional Duty Officer for consideration.

It is also recommended that Units have established plans in place for:

- pre-determined Incident Control Point activation
- pre-identified sectors within the Unit response boundary
- arrangements with other Emergency Services and Council for support response
- activation of the Unit Business Continuity Plans
- activation of Code Red Day plans (if applicable) in line with VICSES Policy 12.01 Code Red (Catastrophic) Day Response.

Unit readiness, activation and planning

For routine day to day operations involving a single crew attending a single incident, the Crew Leader will assume the role of IC where VICSES is the Control Agency.

Where activity levels see multiple crews and/or a low level of multiple incidents the IC should operate from a facility that is capable of running an Incident Control Point.

Once there is the need for deployment of significant resources beyond initial response and neighbouring Units, and/or sectorisation of the emergency event, and/or the establishment of functional sections due to the levels of complexity or the size (particularly the establishment of a public information unit to manage warnings and advice) an ICC should be established with the IC establishing an IMT and relevant EMT.

MULTI AGENCY OPERATIONS

In line with JSOP 2.03 IMT Readiness Arrangements, VICSES has established VICSES Readiness and Activation Triggers to outline the required level of prepositioned response to a forecast or no notice event. A copy of these trigger documents is available via EM-COP.

Where events meet the trigger points for Readiness and Activation Levels of 3B and above, the response to an event moves from 'Business as Usual' response by VICSES, to a multi-agency response as outlined in JSOP 2.03 IMT Readiness Arrangements.

Resources from other Emergency Service Organisations will be deployed to assist with tasks such as IMT roles and incident response.

In line with JSOP 2.03 IMT Readiness Arrangements, predetermined footprints for Incident Control Centres in response to Flood and Storm events have been established.

Managing the incident response

USE OF POWERS UNDER THE VICSES ACT

VICSES policy 12.10 Use of Powers under the VICSES Act during Operations outlines the policy requirements including those authorised to undertake actions in accordance with:

- Section 32AB of the VICSES Act 2005 which provides the power to enter land or premises without the consent of the occupier of the land or premises if a Service member reasonably believes that entry to the land or premises is urgently required to protect life or property in the course of responding to, or preparing for, a flood, earthquake or storm; or providing a rescue service.
- Section 32AC of the VICSES Act 2005 which provides the power to construct, remove or alter a levee on land or premises if it is determined that the construction, removal or alteration is required to protect life or property.
- Section 32AC of the VICSES Act 2005 which enables the service to remove from land or premises debris (including any fallen tree) if that removal is required to protect life or property.

ENTERING LAND OR PREMISES DURING OPERATIONS

Only ICs, VICSES Crew Leaders and VICSES Agency Commanders at Incident, Regional and State Tier are authorised to make a decision to enter property with oral consent or without the consent of occupiers.

VICSES SOP035 Entering Land or Premises During Operations outlines the procedure for entering land and/or premises with oral consent or without the consent of the occupier(s) during emergency operations.

LEVEE CONSTRUCTION, REMOVAL, ALTERATIONS AND DEBRIS REMOVAL

The decision to construct, remove or alter a levee during an emergency rests with the following authorised persons:

- SRC
- RC
- State or Regional Agency Commander
- an endorsed Level 2 or Level 3 IC (where appointed).

The decision to construct, remove or alter a levee should be made having first undertaken an Options Analysis which considers the risks and consequences to the community, utilising the approved Options Analysis tool on the EM-COP Library.

The decision to remove debris from a levee rests with an endorsed Crew Leader or a Controller at Incident, Regional or State tiers.

VICSES SOP036 Construction, Removal or Altering of Levee and Removal of Debris outlines the approach to the construction, removal or alteration of levee and removal of debris during emergency operations.

INTELLIGENCE

The existence and development of intelligence supports emergency services to determine the most appropriate course of action to resolve the incident.

Flood intelligence enables an incident management team to determine, the likely impacts, what actions will need to be taken by agencies and what information and advice should be provided to community members.

VICSES works closely with CMAs, DELWP, other agencies and trusted local sources, as appropriate, to ensure available sources of flood intelligence are utilised. Flood Emergency Plans are the key source of flood information this is complemented with realtime data and monitoring.

DATA COLLECTION

In partnership, DELWP, CMAs, VICSES and municipalities coordinate the collection, collation, analysis, interpretation and dissemination of post-flood extent and survey levels and ensure that relevant information is available through the impact assessment process.

Stream gauges and other equipment utilised for flood warning services are maintained and repaired by Regional Water Monitoring Partnerships managed by DELWP.

DATA ANALYSIS

VICSES has entered into agreements with a number of engineering consulting firms to deliver technical services to support the intelligence unit during operations. These agreements include water engineering (capable of providing flood intelligence) and geotechnical engineers (capable of providing advice on levees and dams).

Triage

During business as usual operations, emergency services respond to Requests for Assistance (RFA) in the order in which they are received. If a large number of RFAs are received, a process of triaging should be utilised to prioritise the tasking of emergency personnel.

FLOOD TRIAGE

Consistent with the State Emergency Management Priorities the following triaging priorities are to be adopted during flood events:

TABLE 8: FLOOD TRIAGE PRIORITY

PRIORITY	EXAMPLE
1. RESCUE OF PERSONS	• Rescue from flood water, trapped in cars or buildings.
2. PROTECTION FROM THREAT TO LIFE	• Evacuation of vulnerable people from the flood affected or potential flood affected areas. • Evacuation of people from flood affected or potential flood affected areas. • Restriction of movement of people in flood affected areas (road closures).
3. PROTECTION OF CRITICAL COMMUNITY INFRASTRUCTURE[1]	• Installation of protective barrier to reduce the impact of floodwater on infrastructure. • Ensure maintenance of critical community infrastructure and/or services to the community.
4. PROTECTION OF PRIMARY RESIDENCE	• Installation of protective barrier to reduce the impact of floodwater on infrastructure.

[1] Infrastructure are those items or places necessary for the maintenance of community function e.g. schools, essential services, care facilities, water pumping stations etc.

STORM TRIAGE

Consistent with the State Emergency Management Priorities the following triaging priorities are to be adopted during storm events:

TABLE 9: STORM TRIAGE PRIORITY

PRIORITY	EXAMPLE
1. THREATENED OR ENTRAPPED PERSONS	• Trapped in cars, buildings, etc. • Evacuation of persons, in the event of flash flooding.
2. TRAFFIC HAZARD PRESENTING A POTENTIAL THREAT TO LIFE	• Major arterials, main roads and single access roads.
3. RENDER CRITICAL INFRASTRUCTURE AND COMMUNITY ASSETS SAFE AND PROVIDE PROTECTION FROM FURTHER DAMAGE[1]	• Removal of trees from structure or that are likely to cause further damage. • Tarping to reduce impacts of weather on the structure. • Shoring (if safe to do so) of building to reduce the risk • of collapse. • Flood protection (where possible).
4. RENDER PRIMARY RESIDENCE (BUILDING ONLY) SAFE AND PROVIDED PROTECTION FROM FURTHER DAMAGE[2]	• Removal of trees from primary residence structure or that are likely to cause further damage. • Tarping to reduce impacts of weather on the structure. • Shoring (if safe to do so) of building to reduce the risk of collapse. • Flood protection (where possible).
5. TREE DOWN BLOCKING ACCESS AND/OR EGRESS **• FOR PROPERTY OWNER.** **• FOR PUBLIC FOOTPATHS**	• Removal of tree from driveway and paths that prevent entry and/or exit either by foot or vehicle from property. • Removal of tree from public footpath that has the potential to impede foot traffic.
6. RENDER PRIVATE PROPERTY SAFE AND PROVIDE PROTECTION FROM FURTHER DAMAGE[3]	• Making safe fences. • Removal of trees from structures. • Tarping to reduce impacts of weather on the structure. • Shoring (if safe to do so) of building to reduce the risk of collapse.

[1] Infrastructure are those items or places necessary for the maintenance of community function e.g. schools, essential services, care facilities, water pumping stations etc.

[2] Out buildings and fencing of primary residence are deemed 'private property' and form part of priority 6.

[3] Property includes residence and other private assets, i.e. vehicles.

Public information

INFORMATION AND WARNINGS

Warnings for extreme weather events are provided by the BoM, Melbourne Water and VICSES.

Principles applied in the provision of public information and warnings shall be consistent with the concepts outlined in the Victoria Emergency Warning Protocol and Total Flood Warning System.

Warnings will be issued where predictions are available. In the case where there is no or limited prediction information available, warnings will only be issued based on local knowledge and/or advice from the Incident Emergency Management Team (IEMT).

If the incident crosses the border, warnings and information will be issued in conjunction with the control agency of the neighbouring state.

Under the BOM Service Level Specification for Flood Forecasting and Warning Services for Victoria the Bureau flood forecasting and warning services is confined to dealing with riverine flooding where typical rain-to-flood times are six hours or more. Flash flooding (rain-to-flood times less than six hours) and flooding caused by elevated sea levels are not covered, nor are the weather forecasting and other services the Bureau provides that contribute to the flood forecasting and warning Service, including Severe Thunderstorm and other Weather Warnings, provision of radar data and rainfall forecasts.

The responsibility for flood modelling and prediction services for the Melbourne Metropolitan catchment rests with Melbourne Water.

BOM RESPONSIBILITIES

BOM are required under the Meteorology Act 1955 (Cth), S6.1c for the issue of warnings of gales, storms and other weather conditions likely to endanger life or property, including weather conditions likely to give rise to floods or bushfires.

The official forecasts and warnings for extreme weather and flood events are issued using the following areas:

- river basins (Flood Watches)
- key locations on rivers and creeks (Flood Warnings)
- land and coastal forecast districts (Severe Weather and Severe Thunderstorm Warnings).

The BOM provide forecasts for predicted levels or flood class levels (minor, moderate and major) for some locations in Victoria. Not all flood risk locations across Victoria are covered by this level of service.

The BOM service level standards (SLS) define the nature and type of warnings provided for various locations across the state. Prediction locations are categorised into the following types; forecast, data and information. The prediction type may be quantitative, qualitative or generalised and includes height and timing information where available.

MELBOURNE WATER RESPONSIBILITIES

Melbourne Water acts as a flood prediction and warning agency for Greater Melbourne Metropolitan catchments and provides flood forecasts to the BOM who disseminate official forecasts and warnings.

WATER STORAGE OWNERS RESPONSIBILITIES

Water storage owners are required to provide information to the downstream community where increased flows from the water storage are expected. In the instance that the increased flow will be at or above the minor flood warning level the water storage owner is required to advise BOM in order for flood warnings to be issued.

VICSES RESPONSIBILITIES

VICSES has a duty to ensure timely issue of warnings and information to the community.

Flood

VICSES will issue warnings for flood events on advice of a BoM flood prediction. These warnings contain information such as current flood situation, likely future flood consequences, actions required to protect life and property, how to access further information about flooding and how to obtain emergency assistance.

Storm

VICSES will issue warnings with enhanced community actions and advice, where this adds value to the BOM warning and prediction, and/or the potential for large scale community consequences are foreseen. Where possible local input will be sought to inform messages issued to the community.

Dam

In the instance of dam incidents that have the potential to have community consequences VICSES will support DELWP in providing warning and/or advice to the community.

ISSUING WARNINGS

There are a variety of methods that agencies use to disseminate warnings, and multiple formats should be utilised where possible to allow maximum reach to the affected community.

In the initial stages of some emergencies there may be little or no opportunity to provide a warning. In extreme weather events the warning issued by the BOM may be assessed as the most appropriate warning, with no supplementary warning issued by the control agency.

The following table describes the linkages between the alert category and the types of extreme weather and flood warnings issued by VICSES.

TABLE 10: ALERT LEVELS

ALERT LEVEL	STORM	FLOOD DAM	DAM
ADVICE	• Severe weather • Severe thunderstorm	• Flood watch	• Dam incident
WATCH AND ACT		• Flood (no flood class level) • Minor flood • Moderate flood	• Dam emergency
EMERGENCY WARNING	• Very dangerous • Severe thunderstorm	• Major flood • Prepare to evacuate • Evacuate immediately	• Prepare to evacuate • Evacuate immediately

Community safety options

Community members respond to the threat of an emergency in a variety of ways. A range of safety options, both personal and communal, are required to support their responses.

The range of safety options available should be appropriate to the local circumstances and identified in local plans. Not all safety options will be available in all circumstances, and some options will be more viable for some groups than for others.

SHELTER IN PLACE

Shelter-in-place may be indicated where it is considered that the process of evacuation poses a greater risk to life than that remaining in-situ.

Where indicated, if taking shelter in flash flood environments, people are advised to take shelter in the highest point such as, within a building.

RESCUE

Rescue activities should be seen as an option of last resort, as they place emergency responders into high risk environments. Rescue should only be undertaken by trained personnel.

In flood environments, rescue needs to be considered when planning for evacuation or shelter-in-place is being undertaken.

EVACUATION

Evacuation is a risk management strategy which may be used as a means of mitigating the effects of an emergency or disaster on a community. It involves the movement of people to a safer location.

Flood evacuation plans exist as part of Municipal Flood Emergency Plan in some high risk communities.

Evacuation is conducted in line with the SOP J3.12 Evacuation, and the Evacuation Guidelines.

Levees are primarily a mechanism for the protection of property, not life. No levee is flood proof. Where there is potential for levee over-topping or a levee breach, a decision to evacuate needs to be considered.

ISOLATED PROPERTIES

Isolation of properties can often occur in flood events. Where possible, people should be encouraged to relocate from their property prior to any threat of isolation, as isolation is not without risk.

RESTRICTING ACCESS

Agencies may restrict the access into the incident area to maintain the safety of personnel and community members; and to protect the incident area.

Consequence management

The State aims to achieve a safer and more resilient community through reducing the consequences of emergency events on the community and its values. ICs are responsible for identifying the broader risks and consequences of the emergency and putting in place processes to manage these.

The following outline potential consequences of extreme weather and flood on the state:

- Substantial damage or demand to the continuity to electricity supplies.
- Sustained or widespread critical telecommunication outage.
- Large scale or wide spread evacuation.
- Major disruption to transport infrastructure significantly affecting passenger and freight operations.
- Major economic cost to State.
- Significant loss of water supply for a large community or regional area.
- Significant loss and damage to environment.
- Residual water in the landscape after flood peaks increase risks to human health, community wellbeing and the functioning of regional economies.

Relief and recovery

PROVISION OF RELIEF

The provision of relief is applied consistent with Fundamentals of Emergency Management (Class 1 emergencies). However, during flood events there may be a requirement to focus on the delivery of essential supplies to community members who may be isolated or have chosen to remain with their property.

TRANSITION TO RECOVERY

Due to the potential prolonged nature of flood events, an IC may consider the requirement to transition part of an incident area to recovery agencies, before the response has concluded.

This transition needs to be planned and agreed between the control and recovery agencies.

After an emergency

DEMOBILISATION

Consistent with Fundamentals of Emergency Management (Class 1 emergencies) the removal of response agencies from an incident area is undertaken in a planned and considered way.

Consideration needs to be given for the decontamination and maintenance of vehicles, equipment and clothing, which has been in contact with floodwater. Specific arrangements have been established for the environmentally responsible disposal of sandbags.

PART 4 – REFERENCES AND APPENDICES

FURTHER INFORMATION

DOCUMENT	LOCATION
AFTER ACTON REVIEW FORM	EM-COP > Library > Reviews > Debriefing
AIIMS MANUAL – 4TH EDITION 2017	AFAC website: www.afac.com.au
CASE STUDIES	EM-COP > Library > Reviews-Lessons > Learning Products > Case Studies
CFA/FFMVic FIREFIGHTER REFERENCE MANUAL	CFA online
CFA FIRE AND EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT FIELD GUIDE AND CHECKLISTS	CFA online
CFA/FRV JOINT OPERATIONAL ACTIVITIES MEMORANDUM OF UNDERSTANDING	Agency intranets
EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT TEAM ARRANGEMENTS	EMV website: www.emv.vic.gov.au
FUNDAMENTALS OF EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT (CLASS 1 EMERGENCIES)	EMV website: www.emv.vic.gov.au
JOINT SOPS	EM-COP > Library > Doctrine > JSOPs
SCC STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURES	EM-COP > Library > State Control Centre (SCC) > Procedures
STATE EMERGENCY MANAGEMENT PLAN (SEMP)	EMV website: www.emv.vic.gov.au
TREE HAZARD PICTORIAL GUIDE	EMV website: www.emv.vic.gov.au/treehazard
VIDEO – TREE HAZARD AWARENESS	Fireweb and CFA online

Doctrine

The following is a list of current doctrine that is available.

Business Rules

Mapping Team
Local Mutual Aid Plans – Fire
Requesting & Deploying of Remote Piloted Aircraft Systems
Bushfire Investigation
State Response Controller Endorsement Process

JSOPs

J02.02	Incident Communications Planning
J02.03	Incident Management Team Readiness Arrangements
J02.04	Local Knowledge – Bushfire
J02.06	Readiness Arrangements - Aviation Resources (Bushfire)
J03.02	Incident Naming – Major Emergencies
J03.03	Incident Action Planning
J03.04	Incident Safety Management Functions
J03.06	Incident Briefings
J03.08	Appointment of Regional and Level 3 Incident Controllers

J03.09	Resource Request Process
J03.10	Traffic Management
J03.11	Red Flag Warnings
J03.12	Evacuation for Major Emergencies
J03.15	Transfer of Control and IMT Relocation
J03.16	Significant Event Notification
J03.17	Regional Operations Plan
J03.18	Incident air quality monitoring for community health
J03.19	Managing significant community exposures to fine particles and carbon monoxide in smoke from fires
J04.01	Public Information and Warnings
J08.01	OH&S Incident Reporting and Investigation
J08.02	Dynamic Risk Assessment
J08.03	Tree Hazard – Bushfire Response
J08.04	Managing Potential Asbestos Exposure
J08.05	Health Monitoring
J12.01	Real Time Monitoring and Evaluation

Operational Policy

Emergency Response Driving

SCC/RCC/ICC Contact List

STATE			
STATE CONTROL CENTRE			
	Level 4, 8 Nicholson St East Melbourne 3002	Ph 1300 368 722	sccvic.sccmgr@scc.vic.gov.au
BARWON SOUTH WEST			
REGIONAL CONTROL CENTRE			
Geelong	61 Separation St Geelong 3220	Ph (03) 5221 6667 Fax (03) 5240 2726	rccbsw.all@rcc.vic.gov.au
INCIDENT CONTROL CENTRES			
Casterton	147 Bahgallah Rd Casterton 3311	Ph (03) 5554 2301 Fax (03) 5581 2151	icccas.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Colac	83–85 Gellibrand St Colac 3250	Ph (03) 5233 5565 Fax (03) 5233 5574	icccol.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Geelong	90–94 Furner Ave Bell Park 3215	Ph (03) 9256 7399 Fax (03) 9256 7367	iccgee.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Hamilton	915 Mt Napier Rd Hamilton 3300	Ph (03) 5551 4700 Fax (03) 5571 1636	iccham.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Heywood	12 Murray St Heywood 3304	Ph (03) 5527 0444 Fax (03) 5527 1809	icchew.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Warrnambool	Cnr Raglan Pde and Walsh Rd Warrnambool 3280	Ph (03) 5559 2500 Fax (03) 5560 5296	iccwar.all@icc.vic.gov.au
EASTERN METROPOLITAN			
REGIONAL CONTROL CENTRE			
	272 Maroodah Hwy Chirnside Park 3116	Ph (03) 8739 1391 Fax (03) 8739 1382	rccemr.all@rcc.vic.gov.au

INCIDENT CONTROL CENTRES			
Ferntree Gully	27/69 Acacia Rd Ferntree Gully 3156	Ph (03) 9751 5700 Fax (03) 9751 5705	iccftg.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Woori Yallock	7–9 Symes Rd Woori Yallock 3139	Ph (03) 5961 5917 Fax (03) 5964 7410	iccwor.all@icc.vic.gov.au
GIPPSLAND			
REGIONAL CONTROL CENTRE			
	181 Franklin St Traralgon 3844	Ph (03) 5177 3240 Fax (03) 5177 3284	rccgip.all@rcc.vic.gov.au
INCIDENT CONTROL CENTRES			
Bairnsdale	574 Main St Bairnsdale 3875	Ph (03) 5150 1320 Fax (03) 5152 0444	iccbai.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Bendoc	2 Nichol St Bendoc 3888	Ph (02) 6459 0508 Fax (02) 6459 0522	iccbnd.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Erica	Thomson Valley Hwy Parkers Corner 3825	Ph (03) 5165 2200 Fax (03) 5165 2233	icceri.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Heyfield	1 Firebrace Rd Heyfield 3858	Ph (03) 5139 7756 Fax (03) 5139 7733	icchey.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Leongatha	14A McCartin St Leongatha 3953	Ph (03) 5667 1100 Fax (03) 5662 2408	iccleo.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Noojee	McCarthys Spur Rd Noojee 3833	Ph (03) 5624 8100 Fax (03) 5268 9563	iccnoo.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Orbost	171–173 Nicholson St Orbost 3888	Ph (03) 5161 1333 Fax (03) 5161 1300	iccorb.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Sale	64–66 Foster St Sale 3850	Ph (03) 5149 1201 Fax (03) 5144 5493	iccsal.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Swifts Creek	McMillan Ave Swifts Creek 3896	Ph (03) 5159 5150 Fax (03) 5159 5155	iccswi.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Traralgon	Level 2, 181 Franklin St Traralgon 3844	Ph (03) 5177 3200 Fax (03) 5176 3295	icctra.all@icc.vic.gov.au

GRAMPIANS			
REGIONAL CONTROL CENTRE			
	19 Learmonth Rd Wendouree 3355	Ph (03) 5330 9130 Fax (03) 5329 5582	rccgmp.all@rcc.vic.gov.au
INCIDENT CONTROL CENTRES			
Ararat	31–33 Baird St Ararat 3377	Ph (03) 5352 9600 Fax (03) 5352 5517	iccara.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Ballarat	25 Vickers St Sebastopol 3356	Ph (03) 5335 0700 Fax (03) 5335 0731	iccbal.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Horsham	110 Natimuk Rd Horsham 3400	Ph (03) 5362 0720 Fax (03) 5381 0268	icchor.all@icc.vic.gov.au
HUME			
REGIONAL CONTROL CENTRE			
	89 Sydney Rd Benalla 3672	Ph (03) 5761 0724 Fax (03) 9562 7852	rcchum.rctrl@rcc.vic.gov.au
INCIDENT CONTROL CENTRES			
Alexandra	5 Binns Macrae Rd Alexandra 3714	Ph (03) 5772 0200 Fax (03) 5772 2892	iccale.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Benalla	64 Sydney Rd Benalla 3672	Ph (03) 9256 7799 Fax (03) 9256 7767	iccbnases.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Corryong	2 Jardine St Corryong 3707	Ph (02) 6076 3100 Fax (02) 6076 1348	icccor.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Mansfield	128 Highett St Mansfield 3722	Ph (03) 5733 1200 Fax (03) 5775 1063	iccman.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Ovens	5338 Great Alpine Rd Myrtleford 3737	Ph (03) 5731 1222 Fax (03) 5731 1223	iccove.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Seymour	39 McIntyre St Seymour 3660	Ph (03) 5735 3300 Fax (03) 5735 3381	iccsey.all@icc.vic.gov.au

Shepparton	195–205 Numurkah Rd Shepparton 3630	Ph (03) 5822 9900 Fax (03) 5833 2483	iccshe.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Tallangatta	34 Toowong St Tallangatta 3700	Ph (02) 6071 5300 Fax (02) 6071 2889	ictal.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Wangaratta	1 Ely St Wangaratta 3677	Ph (03) 5720 2300 Fax (03) 5722 3021	iccwan.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Wodonga	55 Moorefield Park Dr Wodonga 3690	Ph (02) 6043 4600 Fax (02) 6059 8210	iccwod.all@icc.vic.gov.au
NORTHERN AND WESTERN METROPOLITAN			
REGIONAL CONTROL CENTRE			
	239 High St Melton 3337	Ph (03) 8746 1400 Fax (03) 8746 1480	rccnwm.rctrl@rcc.vic.gov.au
INCIDENT CONTROL CENTRES			
Burnley	450 Burnley St Richmond 3121	Ph (03) 9665 4545	iccbur.all@icc.vic.gov.au
Sunshine	239 Proximity Dr Sunshine West 3020	Ph 1800 045 939 Fax (03) 9314 6288	iccsun.all@icc.vic.gov.au
SOUTHERN METROPOLITAN			
REGIONAL CONTROL CENTRE			
	Level 3, 45 Assembly Dr Dandenong South 3020	Ph (03) 9767 3840	rccrctrl@rcc.vic.gov.au
INCIDENT CONTROL CENTRE			
Dandenong	Level 3, 45 Assembly Dr Dandenong South 3020	Ph (03) 9767 3800 Fax (03) 9706 7447	iccdan.all@icc.vic.gov.au

emv.vic.gov.au

Working in conjunction with communities, government, agencies and business

